Measurement and analysis of food price levels and inflation in Nunavut, 2017-2025



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All data used in this report, except for the ICFI grocery receipts, are publicly available and can be shared with interested parties. For those interested in replicating some of these estimates, please contact Professor Nicholas Li (Nicholas.li@torontomu.ca).

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Executive Summary

The aim of this report is to provide the most comprehensive analysis of food prices in Nunavut to date. We analyzed multiple sources of Nunavut food price data to provide a comprehensive assessment of current *price levels* (i.e. how the price of a product or basket of products compares to Canadian averages) and recent inflation (i.e. how much prices have increased in Nunavut compared to increases in Canadian average prices). The first section of this report draws on receipts from families receiving individual grocery supports through the Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI)[1] that were digitized, shared with us by Indigenous Services Canada as well as publicly available data sources – the Nunavut Price Survey, published RNFB food basket costs from Nutrition North Canada, scraped prices from retailer websites, and other data sets published by Statistics Canada and the Federal Government – to analyze price inflation and price levels compared to the rest of Canada.

- Nunavut prices for almost all products are higher than in the rest of Canada. But, since the pandemic, food price inflation in Nunavut has been higher than in the rest of Canada, particularly in the 2022-2024, period, when inflation was over 20%, (versus 12% or less in the rest of Canada).
- This resulted in price ratios that increased and reached approximately 1.9 times the Canadian average by late 2024/early 2025 for a broad set of products.
- Given the large dispersion of prices and inflation rates across products in both Nunavut and the rest of Canada, any comparison

[1] The Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI) is a program introduced by the Federal government intended to be anInuit analogue for Jordan's Principle, which applies to First Nations. The program is administered by Indigenous Services Canada (ISC) and has provided a variety of supports to Inuit children, including grocerysupports which were provided to individual families that applied and were approved. See Sinha et al. (2025) for more details.

of prices – at a point in time, or over time – is sensitive to decisions about which products are included and how they are weighted. We show that some comparisons reported by the Nunavut Bureau of Statistics (the "Nunavut Food Basket") and Nutrition North Canada (the "Revised Northern Food Basket") focus on NNC subsidized products or use Canadian comparison group baskets that understate the extent of higher food costs and higher inflation in Nunavut in recent years.

- We present evidence from a range of data sources – ICFI grocery receipts, the Nunavut Price Survey, the RNFB reported by NNC, web-scraped data from online retailers, and government reported living-cost-indexes (used for Federal employee compensation) and poverty lines – that are informative about price differences and changes over time.

In the second section, we assess the factors underlying high prices and inflation such as air and ocean freight costs, subsidies, and retailer margins. We draw on all publicly available sources of data on air and sealift/resupply freight costs, NNC subsidies, retailer annual reports, and phase-in of the ICFI Hamlet voucher program to provide insight into the factors contributing to high food price levels and recent inflation.[2]

- We find large increases in freight costs for both air (20-25%) and marine (25-30%) freight that are comparable in percentage terms to food inflation in recent years. These track comparable freight cost indexes, although air freight in the US declined along with oil prices starting in early 2023 but remained elevated in Nunavut.
- NNC subsidies, even for the most subsidized products, are below the level of published freight costs and have not kept pace with the increase in freight costs over the last seven years.

[2] The ICFI Hamlet voucher program was introduced in Nunavut between July 2023 and March 2025 with starting dates that varied by community. The program provided a $500 per month grocery voucher for each Inuit child in a community, and additional $250 per month for children under the age of three. It was discontinued in March 2025. See Sinha et al (2026) for more details.

The introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher, which represented a substantial increase in community purchasing power, is not associated with large average price increases for products we observe in the data.

- North West Company margins (the main retailer in Nunavut) increased since 2018 and are high relative to other major Canadian food retailers but can only account for about a 5% increase in prices and a 5% higher price ratio.
- For some products and communities, the increase in Southern retail prices and freight cost net of subsidies is more than enough to account for the entire increase in Northern price; while in others it accounts for only a little. In the case of the RNFB, we estimate that for the average Nunavut community with a North West Company store, published freight cost increases are equivalent to 33-52% of the increase in RNFB price, while Southern RNFB price increases are equivalent to 28% of the increase in RNFB price; the combination thus "accounts" for 61-80% of the increase in RNFB prices on average in communities with a North West Company store.

The third section offers some suggestions on how analysis of the cost-of-living in Nunavut can be advanced going forward. We offer recommendations for future data collection and reporting. These include reporting disaggregated product data, collecting more data on prices of unsubsidized products, collecting data on expenditures/quantities purchased to enable economically meaningful aggregation, reporting mode of transport/NNC subsidy applied, ensuring comparisons with the South use comparable baskets of products, and exploring data collection through retailer agreements and web-scraping.

1. Recent inflation in Nunavut

As Inuit, our rights are not yet equal to those of white people because we're still experiencing colonization. And what was put in place to suppress and change the native in the Inuit, some of it is still the same today...If Canada were a whole, you would think that there wouldn't be no crazy shipping prices up here. You would think that you would have the same amount of resources available up here. We may only be a percentage of the entire Canadian population, but we are a people and we matter. These are real struggles. This is what happens. Hear us out.

[When we don't have enough food] I don't mind not going with a meal for a day as long as my girls eat.
Interview 8, Community 1

We have heard before that the prices will go higher ... Our great-grandmother will tell us that, that the price, it will go higher in the future ... to prepare us.
Interview 5, Community 2

[The grocery prices] never went down. And now I'm basically struggling to keep food on the table.

My family's managing with the help of my family ... I have two sisters, my dad, they're willing to help me all the time.
Interview 1, Community 1

[Sometimes I have not enough [food] for until the end of the week because the prices are getting higher ... I don't know what to buy for 40 bucks. If I want to buy Pampers or food, which one should I buy?

I used to work at the Northern Store. But it's hard for me right now ... [I'm] worried about my kids. If I'm not here, what if I'm out long? What if there's something happening there? Because my youngest always climbs up to [the] kitchen table and chairs.
Interview 5, Community 3

As illustrated by the quotes above, reported in Sinha et al. (2026) from community interviews in the Qikiqtaaluk region conducted in early 2026, Nunavut residents struggle with high food prices and perceived high inflation in recent periods. The analysis in this section considers both relative price levels – comparing the price of individual products or a basket of products between Nunavut and the South – and recent inflation, the increase in prices.

1.1 Evidence from Inuit Child First Initiative Individual Food Voucher receipts

1.1.1 Summary of findings

Our analysis of the ICFI receipt data indicates that during the 2022Q1-2024Q2 period, food inflation in Qikiqtaaluk was over 20%, substantially higher than in the rest of Canada. When comparing prices for over 1,700 products to identical products sold in the South, we find a very large dispersion of price ratios, highlighting the importance of *which products* are used for any comparison. We also find differences in price ratios across communities, product groups and the two major retailers. Using data that reflects actual purchasing patterns, we find that the costs of food people actually buy during this period are at least 90% higher in Qikiqtaaluk than the Canadian average and higher inflation resulted in this gap increasing from about 82% at the beginning of 2022 to 96% by mid 2024.

1.1.2 About the ICFI receipt data

Indigenous Services Canada (ISC), which administers the Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI), scanned, digitized, and anonymized grocery receipts collected for purchases made with Individual Grocery Supports and provided us with a (confidential) data set of prices paid for actual purchases in Nunavut.

These data have major advantages compared to other data sets discussed later. The data contain over 322,840 individual price quotes at the store-barcode level. This covers over 16,000 unique barcodes and both major retailers in Nunavut, making it the most comprehensive data set in terms of coverage and disaggregation of products. The data contain prices and quantities that are representative for purchases made with these food vouchers that total over $5.36 million in spending.

These data also have a few important limitations. Data were only collected for grocery support beneficiaries in the 13 communities of the Qikiqtaaluk region, although there are a small number of purchases made in other communities. ICFI food vouchers could only be spent on specific types of products (a restricted set of food that typically includes all NNC subsidy eligible foods and more, as well as baby products, children's clothing, and some household goods, but excludes products like soda and chips) so are not representative of overall expenditure patterns. Coverage varies substantially across communities and over time and the period covered extends only from 2020Q3 to 2024Q4. Given the lack of data for many periods and communities, we restrict our analysis here to the period from 2022Q1-2024Q2 and the 12 Qikiqtaaluk communities. As shown in Figures 1 and 2, even with this restriction we have limited coverage for 2022 Q2-Q4 and very little data for some communities (especially Grise Fiord, Resolute, and Kimmirut).

Figure 1: Share of ICFI Price Quotes by Quarter

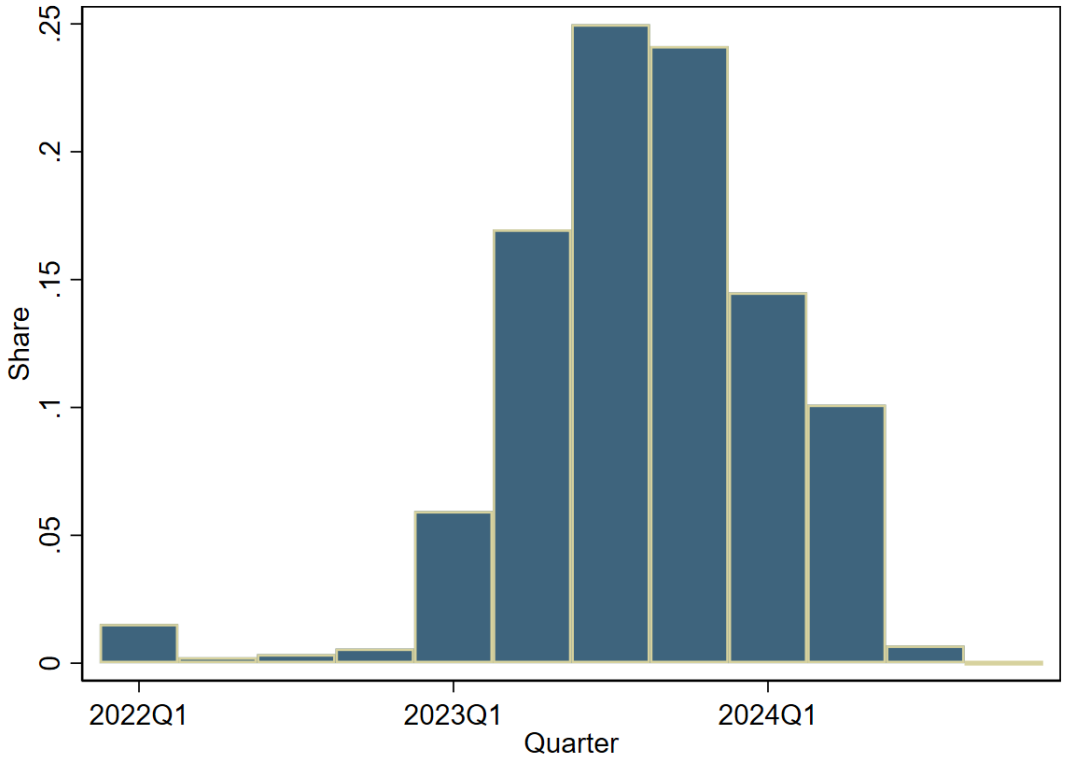
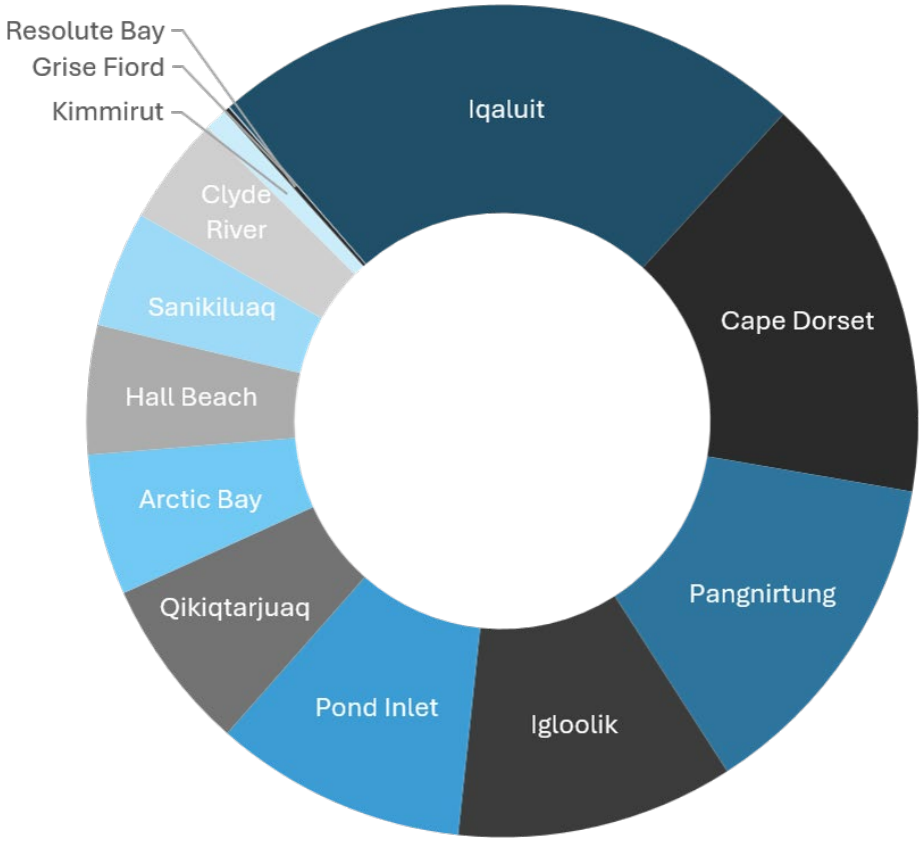


Figure 2: Share of ICFI Price Quotes by Community



1.1.3 Inflation/change in prices

Chapter 3 of Sinha et al. (2025) provides an in-depth analysis of these price data. We reproduce a table from their report, which measures inflation rates in these data using *all* available products. This most comprehensive measure of inflation can be compared to the Canada Food CPI inflation rate over the same period although the content of these baskets is different. Table 1 shows that inflation was substantially higher in the receipt data (which are mostly - though not exclusively - food products) than food inflation in the rest of Canada. There is some variation across communities and product groups, and inflation was generally higher during the 2022Q1-2023Q2 period versus the later 2023Q2-2024Q2 period when several communities phased in the ICFI Hamlet voucher program.

Different methods of weighting products and communities yield somewhat different inflation estimates – some below 26.5%, as

Table 1. ICFI Grocery Support price inflation by period, community, and product category

Measure / group	2022 Q1-2024 Q2	Before HFV phase-in 2022 Q1-2023 Q2	HFV phase-in 2023 Q2-2024 Q2
Canadian food CPI	13.9%	11.1%	2.5%
Qikiqtaaluk	26.5%	17.4%	7.1%
Communities			
Iqaluit	30.2%	17.6%	8.1%
Kinngait	30.9%	21.3%	8.0%
Pangnirtung*	23.8%	10.5%	7.6%
Igloolik*	25.1%	13.9%	8.2%
Pond Inlet*	26.3%	18.0%	7.3%
Product categories			
Baby products	23.0%	12.0%	8.3%
Beverages	26.8%	21.6%	8.4%
Dairy and egg products	27.4%	15.2%	6.8%
Fruits, vegetables, legumes	10.0%	8.4%	3.8%
Grains, cereals, baked goods	33.0%	23.1%	8.8%
Meat and fish	20.0%	12.7%	6.6%

*Note: * Indicates a community that had phased in the HFV Program by 2024 Q2. Columns 3 and 4 may not sum to column 2 because the sets of products compared differ. Canadian food CPI: Statistics Canada Table 18-10-0004-01.*

reported in Table 1, based on applying Tornqvist expenditure share weights -- but regardless of method we find inflation rates in excess of 20% for the whole period, well above the under 14% inflation rate recorded for the food component of the National Consumer Price Index over this period. That is, we found evidence of higher inflation and price divergence for a large (though not

representative or precisely matched) set of food products.

The analysis in Sinha et al. (2025) also considered a price comparison between 21 popular staple products in the ICFI data that could be matched based on product description (but not exact brand/barcode) to average Canadian prices reported by Statistics Canada. The analysis showed that for these 21 products, the average price in the ICFI receipt data rose from 2.06 times higher than the Canadian average in 2022Q1 to 2.32 times higher by 2024Q2, with most of the increase occurring before the end of 2023 and the introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher program.

1.1.4 Price comparisons by retailer

Our earlier analysis in Sinha et al. (2025) pooled across retailers, but we can compare prices and estimate separate inflation rates for the two retailers in the data. Approximately 87% of our price quotes come from the North West Company and the remaining 13% come from Arctic Co-operatives Limited. Most communities in Qikiqtaaluk have both stores, although Clyde River only has a North West Company store and Grise Fiord and Resolute only have a Co-op.

These stores typically sell a similar range of products but often sell different brands. However, in some cases we observe identical barcodes and can provide a direct price comparison. We are not aware of any existing evidence on price or inflation differentials across these chains, which is of interest since they may have different price-setting mechanisms and pricing strategies despite competing directly in most markets. The other available price data considered later – NPS and RNFB data – aggregate to the community level and do not allow such comparisons.

When we compare prices for identical products sold in the same community during the same period (quarter), we estimate that prices at the North West Company stores are 3.5% (weighted by expenditure) to 6% (unweighted) higher than Arctic Co-operatives during this period.

When we construct inflation indexes separately by chain, we estimate that inflation rates for Arctic Co-operatives stores were 4%-7% lower than those for the North West Company during the 2022Q1-2024Q2 period (with overall inflation during this period in the 20-26% range depending on the method of weighting products). These inflation estimates are based on all products with prices observed in both periods, rather than comparing identical products within community, but they suggest that prices were more similar across retailers in 2022Q1 and diverged over this period.

1.1.5 About BetterCart data

With help from BetterCart, a grocery price analytics firm that tracks the online (web) prices of major retail chains in Canada (Loblaws, Sobeys, Metro, various discount banners under these firms, Wal-Mart, and Coops), we precisely matched 1,758 distinct barcodes in the ICFI data. We can therefore compare the prices of the *exact same products* purchased with ICFI vouchers to their price – in the same month – in major Canadian markets (Calgary, Edmonton, Ottawa, Saskatoon, Toronto and Winnipeg). This is important because prices for a given "product" often vary considerably even within the same store given differences across brands and pack sizes, and most existing comparisons of prices or inflation do not examine an identical set of matched products which can introduce noise and potentially bias comparisons.

We were able to match price quotes in the ICFI data to their counterparts in the same month that altogether represent over 18% of all ICFI expenditures. That is, for 18% of all spending captured by the ICFI receipts, we observe a matched price in the South for an identical barcode, recorded in the same month. We can use this to compare relative price levels for matched products in the ICFI data.

These data provide the most comprehensive picture of comparative food prices assembled to date, although they are not representative of all food purchases and many products are excluded from the ICFI data because they were ineligible or not purchased.

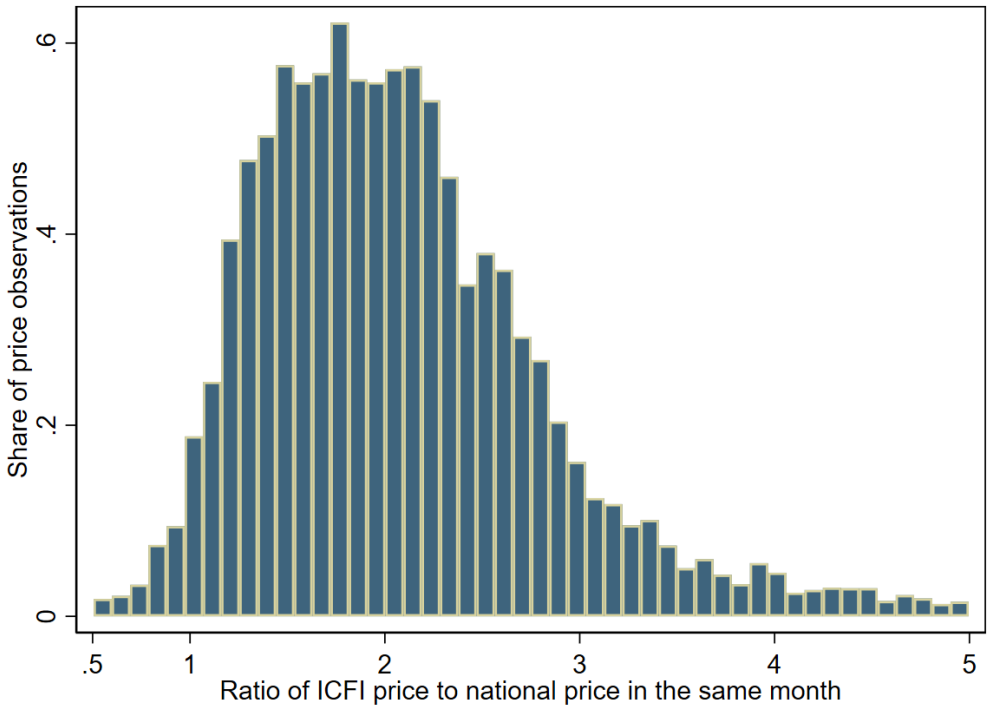
1.1.6 Price ratios by community, product group and retailer

Figure 3 reports a histogram of the price ratio – expressed as the local price relative to the average national price during the same month – for all matched ICFI purchases. The data show a massive variability of price ratios. About 2% of purchases – typically milk – have lower prices in Qikiqtaaluk during this period, while another 1% have prices that are more than 5x higher (dropped from the figure for readability).

This graph shows that many prices in the receipt data are 1.5-2 times as high as comparable products in major Canadian cities, but some prices are 5 times as high or higher. This wide variability suggests that any price comparison with national prices is likely to be sensitive to two factors: (1) which products (and communities) are included and excluded in the comparison, and (2) how they are weighted. Standard practice in the construction of inflation and cost-of-living indexes is to weight prices based on the quantity or expenditure related to that price, so the price ratios of products that are more important in the household basket count for more. However, this kind of data ("representative scanner data") is

only available from retailers themselves.

Figure 3: Ratio of ICFI receipt prices to National prices for matched products



The Survey of Household Spending, which provides representative data on expenditure across food categories and is used to construct the Consumer Price Index, provides estimates of expenditures for Iqaluit, and there are some representative data on shipment quantities for goods subsidized by NNC. But these are measured at a much more aggregate level than individual barcodes. One simple and economically meaningful exercise we pursue here is to calculate the following counterfactual – suppose ICFI recipients in our data could have purchased the exact same set of matched products at national prices, in the same quantities, how much more did they end up paying? This analysis weights products according to their importance in the ICFI basket, which, while not representative of all expenditures, reflects actual consumption choices by households.

Table 2 presents this price ratio data with columns for the share of ICFI expenditure matched, the mean and median ratio (across all matched price quotes) and the "relative cost of the matched ICFI bundle." We report estimates using ICFI data pooled for the entire January 2022 to June 2024 period. The first row reports that overall, the mean price ratio is 2.08, the median is 1.98, and the

relative cost of purchasing the (matched) ICFI bundle is 1.91 compared to the Canadian average

Table 2. ICFI-to-Canadian price ratios and matched-bundle costs, January 2022-June 2024

Group	Share of expenditures matched to Southern prices	Mean price ratio: ICFI vs. Canadian average	Median price ratio: ICFI vs. Canadian average	Matched ICFI bundle cost versus Canadian average
All	0.18	2.08	1.98	1.91
Communities				
Arctic Bay	0.18	2.15	2.03	2.03
Kinngait	0.17	2.14	2.05	1.99
Clyde River	0.16	2.21	2.06	2.05
Grise Fiord	0.19	2.42	2.38	2.47
Sanirajak	0.16	2.09	1.96	1.96
Igloolik	0.16	2.03	1.95	1.92
Iqaluit	0.16	1.94	1.83	1.77
Kimmirut	0.19	1.99	1.79	1.81
Pangnirtung	0.18	2.11	2.07	1.90
Pond Inlet	0.14	2.14	2.02	1.92
Qikiqtarjuaq	0.16	2.16	2.14	2.03
Resolute Bay	0.19	1.84	1.69	1.70
Sanikiluaq	0.13	1.98	1.84	1.84

Note: Price ratios compare local prices with Canadian average prices for the same product and month. The matched-bundle measure weights products by quantities purchased through ICFI Grocery Supports.

Table 2. ICFI-to-Canadian price ratios and matched-bundle costs, January 2022-June 2024 (continued)

Group	Share of expenditures matched to Southern prices	Mean price ratio: ICFI vs. Canadian average	Median price ratio: ICFI vs. Canadian average	Matched ICFI bundle cost versus Canadian average
Product categories				
Baby products	0.09	1.28	1.30	1.28
Dairy and egg products	0.25	1.68	1.49	1.72
Fruits, vegetables, legumes	0.20	2.47	2.54	2.44
Grains, cereals, baked products	0.11	1.80	1.79	1.77
Meat	0.07	1.58	1.45	1.34
Nuts, sauces, spices, oils	0.12	1.47	1.41	1.43
Retailers				
Arctic Co-operatives Ltd.	0.18	2.06	1.97	1.96
North West Company	0.16	2.08	1.98	1.91

Note: Price ratios compare local prices with Canadian average prices for the same product and month. The matched-bundle measure weights products by quantities purchased through ICFI Grocery Supports.

The remaining rows of the table split up the ICFI data based on community, then major product category (based on our classification method discussed in Sinha et al., 2025), then retailer.[3]

The community estimates, which can be compared to later estimates based on other sources of price data, suggest that Grise Fiord, Clyde River, Qikiqtarjuaq and Arctic Bay are the most expensive communities and Resolute, Iqaluit, Sanikiluaq and Kimmirut are among the cheapest.

The category estimates suggest that, while all food categories are more expensive, fruits and vegetables have the highest relative premium while meat has the smallest premium, with dairy and grains falling in the middle. This is largely in line with the findings in Daley et al. (2026) who analyze product-level data from RNFB products that can be matched to Statistics Canada average product prices and find ratios of 2.6 for fruits/vegetables, 1.91 for dairy, 1.8 for grains and 1.07 for meat products for 2021 NNC data for all NNC communities eligible for the full subsidy.

The retailer-specific estimates show fairly similar price ratios for the full set of matched products purchased with ICFI vouchers. This contrasts with our finding reported earlier that for identical products sold in the same community in the same quarter, prices are on average somewhat lower in the Co-op during this period.[4]

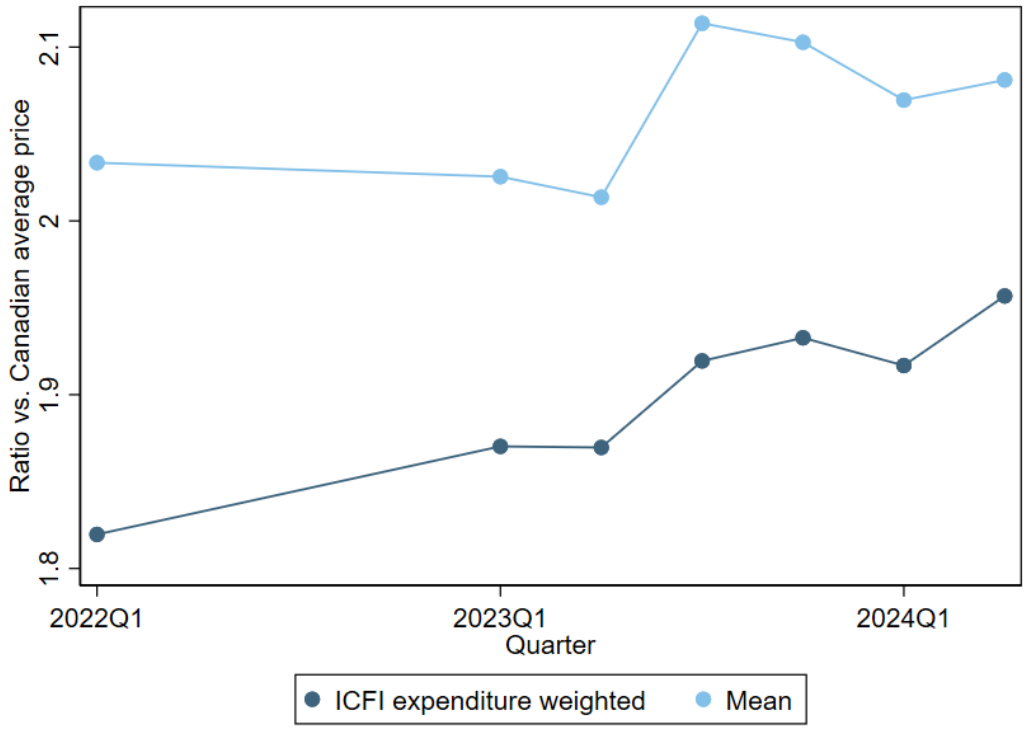
While the table pools data from the entire period, we can also track this ratio over time. In Figure 4, we report estimates for quarters where we have a reasonable number of price quotes. For matched products, the mean price ratio rose from 2.03 to 2.08 over this period, while the relative cost of purchasing the ICFI bundle rose from 1.82 to 1.96. The larger increase for the latter bundle suggests that the price ratio rose by more for products that were

[3] While we focus on comparisons with the Canadian average to maximize product coverage, the mean ratio is almost identical when comparing to Ottawa (2.09), which is sometimes used for comparison (e.g. in the Nunavut Price Survey). When comparing to Ottawa (or the Canadian average), the price ratio is lower (1.97) if we ignore temporary/bulk sales prices and only use "regular" prices. Sales are common in our Southern comparison data but very rare in the ICFI data, where they appear primarily as bulk discounts. Standard practice is to use the actual prices paid, which sometimes include sales for some products, which we follow for the rest of our analysis.

[4] This reflects differences across communities and time (since these estimates do not compare identical products sold in the same community in the same month), and the fact that Southern matched products are only a subset of all products sold.

purchased in greater quantities by ICFI recipient households.

Figure 4: ICFI Prices vs. Canadian Average Prices, 2022–2024



Note that the analyses of inflation rates and relative prices, do not hold constant the basket of products over time but rather aim to capture the broadest set of products available and use weights that best reflect actual consumption. If we restrict to only a set of products that are observed in each period/community, as well as in the rest of Canada, we can construct an estimate of the cost of a "fixed" bundle of products (fixing the set of products and their weights) and show how this has changed over time. This allows for an additive decomposition of price levels in Nunavut and the rest of Canada, and the fixed basket concept is similar to some that we consider later (e.g. the 24 product "Nunavut Food Basket" costed by the Nunavut Bureau of Statistics, and the "Revised Northern Food Basket" costed by Nutrition North Canada). The set of products that are observed in all three periods for a given community and in the matched BetterCart/Canadian data is much smaller than the estimates we have reported so far. For these 86 products, we can see that roughly

half of the increase in Qikiqtaaluk prices from 2022Q1 to 2023Q2 is consistent with the increase in the rest of Canada, leaving about half as "excess" inflation. In the second period from 2023Q2 to 2024Q2, the price increase in Qikiqtaaluk is much smaller but an even smaller share of this (about 20%) is "accounted for" by the increase in the rest of Canada.

Table 3. Fixed matched ICFI basket price index, 2022 Q1-2024 Q2

Location	2022 Q1	2023 Q2	2024 Q2
Canada	100.00	115.64	117.90
Qikiqtaaluk	181.10	209.66	220.08

Note: The basket contains 86 product-community combinations observed in all three periods and in the BetterCart/Canadian comparison data. Canada in 2022 Q1 is normalized to 100.

1.2 Evidence from the Nunavut Price Survey

1.2.1 Summary of findings

Our analysis of the Nunavut Price Survey data suggests that the 24 product basket (deemed the "Nunavut Food Basket") highlighted in the recent Nunavut Bureau of Statistics report (Nunavummit Kiglisiniartiit,2026) provides a potentially misleading assessment of Nunavut prices. This basket, which only includes NNC subsidized products, implies that Nunavut food prices are only 50% higher than the rest of Canada in March 2025 (down from 63% in March 2017) and that Nunavut food inflation was only 16.3% (~2% a year) from 2017-2025. Estimates based on a more comprehensive basket of items collected by the Bureau using the same methodology imply a higher relative price level (88%-96% higher in March 2025) and a higher 2017-2025 inflation rate (up to 36.8%). This difference is partly explained by NNC subsidies, which lower freight costs and also increased during the 2017-2025 period.

1.2.2 About the Nunavut Price Survey

The Nunavut Price Survey, conducted by the Nunavut Bureau of Statistics, was recently conducted in March 2025 and released to the public in April 2026. The survey was conducted across all 25 communities in Nunavut from 45 different stores

and included 141 items and 19 non-food items. Prices for specific retailers and brands are not reported, but the survey did collect price data for multiple pack sizes and in some cases recorded multiple "varieties" of a given item (e.g. yellow vs. red potatoes, 1% vs. 2% milk, different cuts of steak), increasing the maximum set of potential products (by product name/size/variety) to 635.

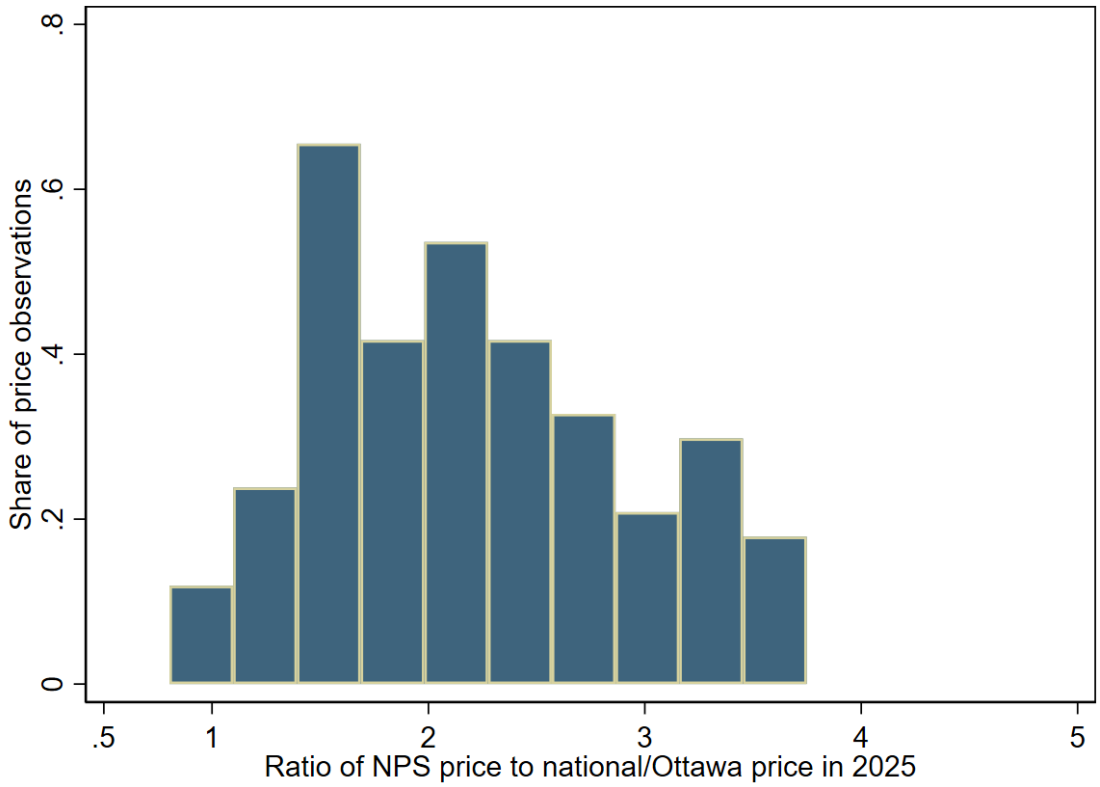
The public release includes the average price of 24 food products (the "Nunavut Food Basket") for each community[5] along with the average price per kilogram for a (partly overlapping) list of 46 food products. All products on the 24 product list are NNC eligible, while the 46 product list includes some non-subsidized products including soft drinks, potato chips, macaroni and cheese dinner, canned luncheon meat and chocolate bars. The published data also include the contemporaneous Ottawa price for the 24 product list and for 42 out of the 46 items on the longer list.[6] The 24 and 46 product lists were also released in 2017, which allows for comparisons over time.

The Nunavut Bureau of Statistics also provided us with a detailed list of items priced, which includes all 141 items and multiple pack sizes/varieties. This provides us with up to 635 distinct prices per community, although some of the listed pack sizes/varieties are missing in every community. In earlier years like 2017, these detailed data were released publicly although the total number of distinct prices was only 417. We manually matched detailed products and found 319 distinct product/size/variety combinations that are priced in both the 2017 and 2025 surveys.

[5]This bundle is called the "Nunavut food basket" by the Nunavut Bureau of Statistics and is comprised of 24 food products "are regularly purchased across the territory" according to REPORT. It includes 2%, Margarine, Eggs, Frozen Corn, Frozen French Fried Potatoes, Frozen Pizza, Soda Crackers,Canned Salmon, Pink Canned Baked Beans, Canned Cream of Mushroom Soup, Instant Rice, Spaghetti Noodles, Macaroni and Cheese Dinner, Oatmeal, White Flour, Baby Food in Jars, White Bread, Apples,Bananas,Carrots, Potatoes, Ground Beef, Pork Chops and Hot Dog Wieners.

[6] Certain products on the 46 item list that were priced in Nunavut - UHT milk, Pilot Biscuits, and single soda cans - were not priced in Ottawa, likely because they were not available in the store chosen for comparison.

Figure 5: Nunavut Price Survey: Prices Relative to Ottawa/Canada



For Ottawa prices in 2025, we match products from the full list of items priced in Nunavut to average Canadian prices reported by Statistics Canada or use Ottawa prices collected for the 24/46 item list if available. For 2017, we use the full list of items priced in Ottawa (where available) to fill in the prices for the 24 item basket (the Ottawa prices for the 46 item basket are already reported).

1.2.3. Price analysis

As noted in Nunavummit Kiglisiniartiit (2026), in March 2025 the average cost of purchasing the 24 product "Nunavut Food Basket" in Nunavut was 1.5 times higher than the cost of purchasing the same basket in Ottawa. This is based on averaging the price (where available) across all Nunavut communities and adding up the cost of all 24 products using these average prices, using whatever pack size/quantity of each product that was selected for the basket.

This number is potentially misleading, as a more comprehensive analysis of prices – one that includes more products, and especially more unsubsidized products – suggests a larger gap. As with the ICFI data, there is wide dispersion in price ratios

in our data. For the 116 products we matched to Ottawa or Canadian average prices in 2025, the distribution of price ratios is given in Figure 5. There is somewhat less dispersion compared to the ICFI data (i.e. there are few products with lower prices and none with prices more than 4 times higher) but the overall distribution is similar and highlights that the choice of which products to include, and how they are weighted, is an important consideration in any analysis.

In Table 4 columns 1 and 2, we report price ratios for the 24, 46 and all item baskets for 2017 and 2025, using the same methodology, i.e. we first calculate the Nunavut average price for each product (ignoring missing prices), and then add the cost of all of the items in the basket. We then compute the ratio of this cost to the cost of purchasing the same basket in Ottawa (and/or at Canadian average prices where Ottawa prices are unavailable). For the all item basket, we can either consider the maximum possible set of comparisons (over time, or between Nunavut and Ottawa/national average) or only a consistent set of 84 common products with prices available in both Ottawa/national average and Nunavut data in both 2017 and 2025. Our estimates show that the 1.5 times higher cost reported for the 24 product basket in March 2025 is low relative to other feasible comparisons. Baskets with 46, 84, or up to 116 products have March 2025 price ratios between 1.88 and 1.96 times higher than Ottawa/the national average. The price ratio has also increased since 2017 for these larger baskets, and the 2025 ratios are more in line with our estimates based on ICFI data from 2022-2024, as well as estimates of relative living costs reported later (IPAI and MBM). The 24 item basket appears anomalous in this respect, as the relative cost of this basket has actually *decreased* between 2017 and 2025. In columns 3 and 4, we calculate Nunavut inflation rates over the 2017-2025 period, which can be compared to food inflation in the rest of Canada. As before we use average Nunavut prices. Inflation calculated using the 24-item basket is 16.3% but this number rises considerably, ranging from 25.6% to 35.8% when we use larger baskets.

Table 4. Nunavut Price Survey price ratios and inflation, 2017-2025

Basket / specification	Price ratio 2025	Price ratio 2017	Nunavut inflation 2017-2025	Ottawa inflation 2017-2025
24-product bundle	1.50	1.63	16.3%	26.0%
46-product bundle	1.88	1.69	35.4%	24.1%
All available products	1.88	1.74	36.8%	16.5%
Number of products	116	361	319	84
Common-products specification	1.96	1.82	25.6%	16.5%
Number of products	84	84	84	84
Canadian CPI food-at-home inflation	—	—	—	35.8%

Note: Ottawa or Canadian average prices are used where available. Product counts vary across calculations; the common-products specification uses the same 84 products throughout.

These inflation numbers for Nunavut can be compared to the rest of Canada. The Food-at-home component of the Consumer Price Index shows 35.8% inflation over this period, similar to the high end estimate for Nunavut. However, the Consumer Price Index includes different items than the ones included in the Nunavut Price Survey, and weights items based on expenditure share weights, so this is not an apples-to-apples comparison. We can estimate inflation rates for Ottawa for identical 24 and 46 item baskets, and for the larger basket (under the assumption that Ottawa prices are close to the national average, which seems approximately correct given our analysis of ICFI data in the previous section). Inflation rates for these baskets in Ottawa are much lower than the increase in the Canada Food-at-home CPI, ranging from 16.5% for the most comprehensive basket to 26% for the 24 product basket.

Our analysis of inflation highlights that the 24 product basket is unusual – it exhibits a lower ratio of prices in any period, and also exhibits lower inflation relative to the rest of Canada between 2017 and 2025.

One explanation for this is that the 24 product basket only includes NNC subsidized products. Because NNC subsidy rates increased between 2017 and 2025, and tend to lower prices, we would expect both (a) lower price ratios using the 24 product basket at any point in time and (b) lower inflation for NNC subsidized products over this period (at least holding all else equal). There are other factors that may also play a role. For instance, the weight/value ratio of products matters, since products with a higher weight/value ratio face a higher "freight" tax when shipped North, which tends to (a) raise price ratios and (b) lead to higher inflation during periods of rising freight costs.

1.3 Evidence from the Revised Northern Food Basket

1.3.1 Summary of findings

Nutrition North Canada's (NNC) Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB) measures the cost of a specific basket. Nunavut's RNFB prices were relatively stable for many years, decreasing as a result of the transition from Food Mail to NNC and rising slowly only to fall again due to subsidy rate increases in 2019 and 2020. Ever since, RNFB prices have increased substantially, despite a (small) subsidy rate increase in 2023. Since the pandemic, RNFB prices have risen faster than Canadian Food-at-home CPI inflation, and the latter index overstates inflation in the rest of Canada compared to a more comparable basket of products. Using a more comparable basket, we estimate that inflation in Nunavut was almost twice as high as the rest of Canada between March 2021 and March 2025, and almost three times as high from March 2022 to March 2025. We find that the inflation comparisons emphasized in NNC's reporting focus on very long-run (March 2011 to March 2025) or very recent (e.g. April 2023 to March 2024) comparisons of RNFB inflation with Canadian Food-at-home inflation, which understates the decline in absolute and relative RNFB affordability in Nunavut due to the choice of dates and the use of a less comparable basket.

1.3.2 About the RNFB

Nutrition North Canada publicly reports the estimated cost of a 67 product basket with product weights that correspond to a one week diet for a family of four called the Revised Northern Food Basket. Data were historically reported quarterly (March, June, September, December) and are provided by retailers. Prices are first calculated on a per KG/L basis and averaged across all NNC-

registered retailers and related products (brands, pack sizes) in a community, then aggregated using fixed weights. When a product's price is missing it is imputed by NNC using an undisclosed methodology. The RNFB fixed product weights are based on a diet designed by a dietitian that supposedly accounts for elements of local preferences, but is known to significantly differ from actual diets (for instance, see Daley, Galloway, Li and Watson (2026) who compare RNFB diet data on NNC subsidized shipments and the Survey of Household Spending for Iqaluit).

After changes in its reporting system and methodology delayed release of new data for several years, NNC recently released three new years of data covering April 2022 through March 2025 and now reports data on a monthly basis. Historically NNC's RNFB estimates did not include data for Arctic Co-Operatives for "data quality" reasons, but starting in October 2023 it contributes to these public figures; this means that previously, the data represent prices for the North West Company only and there were no reported prices for the four Nunavut communities with no North West Company store. [7]

Prior to the introduction of NNC a different method (based on manual price collection rather than data sent by retailers to NNC) was used and this included both major retailers and the four missing communities, so we have some potentially comparable data collected between 2008 and 2010 for all Nunavut communities (with prices averaged across retailers, where applicable) under Food Mail.

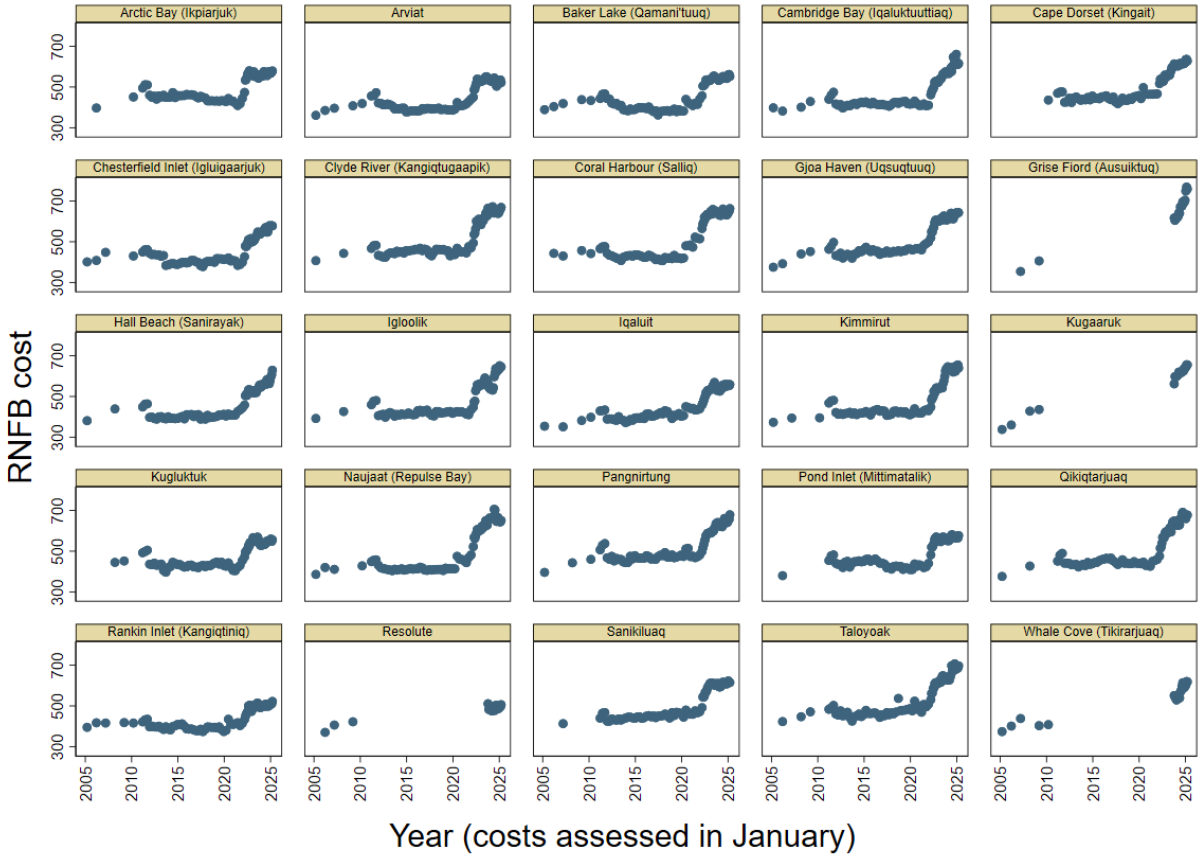
NNC does not provide a comparison RNFB cost for Ottawa or the rest of Canada, but on the NNC website RNFB reporting section, changes in RNFB costs are benchmarked against changes in the Canada Food-at-home CPI. Prior to NNC (under Food Mail) there was some costing of the RNFB in Ottawa. For our analysis here, we have constructed a Canada RNFB cost using average Canadian product prices for 37 products for which we could closely match the

[7] In our analysis of inflation we use March 2024 as the endpoint as it represents the most recent price data reported, even though it includes Arctic Co-Operatives stores and so is not exactly comparable even using the same set of 21 communities with North West Company stores (20 of which have an Arctic Co-Op). We do this in part because the introduction of Arctic Co-Operatives into the RNFB calculation does not appear to have any significant effect on prices. For communities with both stores, we observe a $4.71 increase in RNFB costs from September 2023 to October 2023 (the first date that Arctic Co-Operatives are included) corresponding to only a 0.72% percentage increase.

product description.[8] These product-level prices are available since 2017. We use weights corresponding to the RNFB weights, and our matched basket makes up over 40KG out of a total RNFB weight of 51.8KG. As the RNFB includes only a limited set of food products and puts significant weight on a subset of these products, this Canada RNFB is likely to provide a better representation of inflation in the cost of a similar basket of goods purchased at average Canadian prices relative to an index like the CPI Food-at-home index.

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Figure 6: RNFB cost, over time, by Nunavut communities



[8] These data come from Statistics Canada Table 1810024501, available here: https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/t1/tbl1/en/tv.action?pid=1810024501
Note that we cannot compare price levels with Nunavut, since we are missing 30 products, but we can still measure inflation for the 37 product (weighted) basket at Canadian average prices.

1.3.3 Price analysis

Figure 6 provides a scatter plot of the raw RNFB data for each Nunavut community over time. It shows that for the communities with consistent data, RNFB prices fell slightly with the introduction of NNC (comparing periods before March 2012 with periods after), displayed stability or small increases in the years leading up to the coronavirus pandemic, and surged in recent years, despite subsidy rate increases that occurred in January 2019, May 2020, and February 2023. Although the pattern over time is similar, there is also some variability across communities in the magnitude of increases and the cost of the RNFB in any given period.

Table 5. RNFB inflation in Nunavut and Canadian benchmarks, by comparison period

Comparison period (communities and retailers)	Nunavut RNFB	Canadian RNFB	Canadian food CPI
2006-2010 to March 2025 (25 communities, both retailers)	44.3%		61.8%
March 2011-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	33.7%		52.4%
March 2012-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	44.0%		49.1%
March 2017-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	44.4%	35.2%	36.7%
March 2019-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	43.3%	25.3%	29.7%
March 2021-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	41.4%	21.0%	24.6%
March 2022-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	28.1%	10.4%	15.7%
April 2022-March 2025 (21 communities, North West Company)	19.8%	8.7%	14.7%

Note: The Canadian RNFB is a weighted basket of 37 matched RNFB products priced using Canadian averages. Entries in red denote numbers emphasized in NNC analysis.

Table 5 provides estimates of the average RNFB inflation rate across Nunavut communities with March 2025 as the end point but different starting points. We also provide estimates of Canada Food-at-home CPI inflation for each period, as well as the more comparable Canada RNFB described above. [9]

In the first row, we use the most recent available price observation collected under the Food Mail program, which allows us to estimate inflation for all communities and across both retailers. This estimate shows that average RNFB inflation in Nunavut was 44.3%, well below the 61.8% Canada CPI food inflation over the same period.

In the second row, we use data for March 2011 as the base period, which omits data from Arctic Co-Op and the four Nunavut communities where it was the only retailer. This period can be considered "pre-NNC" although it marks a transition period (ending in March 2012) during which subsidies were not fully phased in. Once again RNFB inflation is lower than for the Canada food CPI. This comparison period, which is emphasized by NNC in its comments on the RNFB price reports on its website, makes inflation in Nunavut appear substantially lower than in the rest of Canada. [10]

In the third row, we begin from March 2012, after NNC subsidies were fully phased in, and again we see RNFB inflation below Canada Food CPI inflation although the magnitudes are more similar.

When we consider more recent periods, the picture looks very different. Beginning in March 2017, RNFB inflation is higher than Canadian food inflation. The 44.4% RNFB inflation rate over this period is somewhat higher than 36.8% inflation rate for the most comprehensive set of products in the Nunavut Price Survey. [11] The RNFB data confirm that the net effect of all of the subsidy increases, changes in freight costs, and changes in other retailer operating costs and margins since March 2017 was RNFB inflation

[9] Note that we cannot compare RNFB costs in levels with our methodology, since we do not have Southern prices for 30 products in the RNFB (making up approximately 20% of the weight). However, if we assumed that the missing products had a similar cost per weight, we can derive an estimate of $245.22 for March 2024 of our Canada RNFB, which is much lower than the mean RNFB for Nunavut at $579.44. This represents a ratio of 2.36, above what we estimate using any other data, and much higher than the 1.90 we estimate for 2010 which is the last time the RNFB was priced in Ottawa.

[10] See https://www.nutritionnorthcanada.gc.ca/eng/1774270580045/1774270688591 and https://www.nutritionnorthcanada.gc.ca/eng/1776276215625/1776276279455

in Nunavut that exceeded the Canadian food-at-home CPI inflation.

When we consider "Canadian RNFB inflation," which is more comparable to the RNFB because it uses similar products and weights, inflation in Nunavut looks even higher in relative terms. Nunavut RNFB inflation was almost double Canadian RNFB inflation from March 2021 to March 2025, and almost three times higher from March 2022 to Mach 2025.

This is an important finding, as the NNC website benchmarks changes in RNFB costs against Canadian Food CPI rather than a basket of goods that more closely resembles the product selection and weighting in the RNFB. Our Canada RNFB inflation estimates are lower than those based on Canadian Food CPI in recent periods, particularly since 2019.

In addition to the importance of using a comparable basket, the change in reporting system/data methodology that occurred between March 2022 and April 2022 deserves greater scrutiny. This change resulted in an 8% increase in inflation in one month, so using March 2022 or earlier as the start date (compared to April 2022 or later) has a large impact on the estimated level of inflation and comparisons with the rest of Canada. NNC's comments on its official RNFB price reporting in recent years (e.g. for the 2022-2023 fiscal year) use April 2022 instead March 2022 for measuring and comparing inflation, instead of its usual practice of comparing prices March to March, which makes RNFB inflation appear relatively lower.

Nunavut inflation is higher using either month as the starting point, particularly when comparing to Canada RNFB inflation instead of CPI Food inflation, but since the jump in prices is not well explained on the website, it would be helpful for NNC to clarify how and why the change in reporting system/data resulted in such a large jump in the index. If the updated/post-April 2022 numbers are considered more accurate, it would be helpful to understand how analysis of price changes using earlier data may have been biased.

Figure 7 summarizes these patterns by plotting the average March price of the RNFB for the 21 Nunavut communities with consistent reporting (i.e. North West Company prices) along with 10 Qikiqtaaluk communities. For comparison, we include the estimated dollar cost of the Southern comparison RNFB (which requires that we impute the cost of unmatched products – we assume that the cost per kilogram is

the same for unmatched products for simplicity [11]) and the "food purchased from stores" CPI which we set (arbitrarily) equal to $100 in March 2022 for easier comparison. Thus, these comparisons can be made in levels (to each other) and over time compared to themselves (i.e. inflation).

Figure 7: RNFB and Comparison Prices

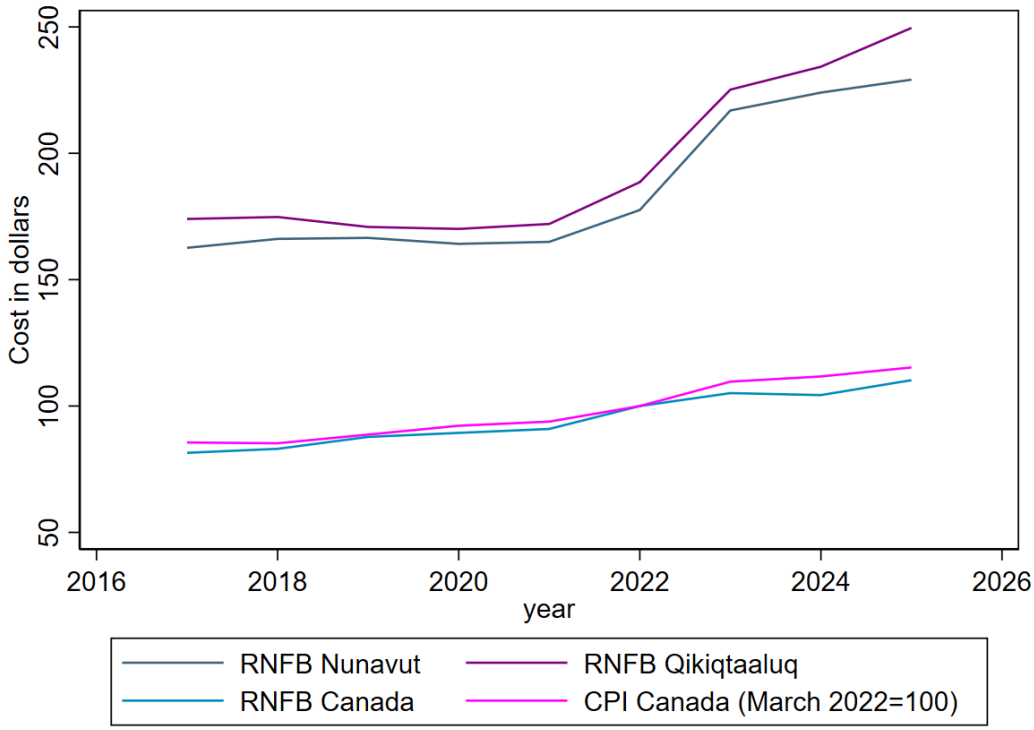


Figure 7 shows that prices in the North began to seriously diverge in 2022 after a period of slow convergence that was likely related in part to subsidy increases in 2019 and 2020. In 2022, prices were about 90% higher in Qikiqtaaluk and 75% higher in Nunavut as a whole. The greatest divergence occurred in 2022 and 2023, which were periods of high inflation in the South but much higher inflation in Nunavut. After 2023 prices continued to rise in Nunavut but at a slower rate, although Qikiqtaaluk saw another notable uptick in prices between

[11] Specifically, we match 40KG out of 51.8KG of RNFB weight, so we impute the dollar cost of the Canadian RNFB in levels by multiplying the cost by a factor of 1.29 to equalize the weight. This assumes that the cost per kilogram of unmatched products is the same as for matched products – this is a strong assumption that is necessary to make comparisons in levels, but does not affect inflation calculations for the set of matched products.

2024 and 2025. We also see that the cost of food purchased from stores (according to national CPI) and the estimated Canadian RNFB track each other quite closely in the long run, but the Canadian RNFB had notably lower inflation after 2022. Overall, our analysis highlights three broad facts about RNFB costs in Nunavut. First, Nunavut RNFB inflation was low in the 2010s, in part because NNC lowered RNFB prices. RNFB inflation was lower than Canadian food inflation, although we do not have data to assess whether it was lower than Canadian RNFB inflation. In the 2020s, Nunavut RNFB inflation has been greater than inflation in the rest of Canada, especially when using a more comparable basket, with the most notable divergence occurring after 2020 (the last major increase in NNC subsidies). Since March 2019, Nunavut RNFB inflation was 2 times higher than Canada RNFB inflation and as much as 5 times higher since 2022, when food and energy inflation surged globally. Third, NNC's reporting uses Canada prices that are less comparable and has focused on specific short and long-term periods rather than medium-run trends. Both of these choices tend to understate the extent to which RNFB affordability in Nunavut has deteriorated relative to the rest of Canada in the last four to five years.

1.4 Evidence from online retailers

1.4.1 Summary of findings

Online retailer websites provide an opportunity to collect real time price data, as well as the contribution of base prices versus freight costs and subsidies, for thousands of products, and can in some cases be used to estimate an "online RNFB." For March 2024, the Arctic Fresh RNFB is much higher than the NWCO/ACO local RNFB for many communities. From early 2024 to mid/late 2025, there was high but variable inflation for RNFB products across (mostly Qikiqtaaluk) communities for both Arctic Fresh and Northern Shopper prices, in the 20-40% range for most communities. This inflation was higher when applying RNFB weights, and for Northern Shopper the ratio of landed/delivered to base price cost increased from 2024 to 2025 suggesting that rising freight costs (with no change in NNC subsidies) contributed to "excess" inflation.

1.4.2 About the data

We collected data on the prices of products in the RNFB, inclusive of freight and subsidy, from the websites of Arctic Fresh and the Northern Shopper in early 2024 and

mid/late 2025. Arctic Fresh serves all Qikiqtaaluk communities as well as Rankin Inlet and Kuujjuaq in Nunavik, and we collected the all-inclusive delivered price (net of freight and NNC subsidy). The Northern Shopper services all Qikiqtaaluk communities except Grise Fiord and Sanikiluaq and we collected a breakdown of base prices, freight costs and subsidy applied per item.

For Arctic Fresh we are able to closely match 61/67 RNFB products, accounting for 50.3 out of 51.8 KG of the total weight of the RNFB (we matched less in Iqaluit where the research assistant failed to record two important products). We can apply exact RNFB weights, providing the first (to our knowledge) estimate of an online retailer price for this basket that can be compared to NNC reported figures for local retailers, or aggregate the products using equal or other weights.

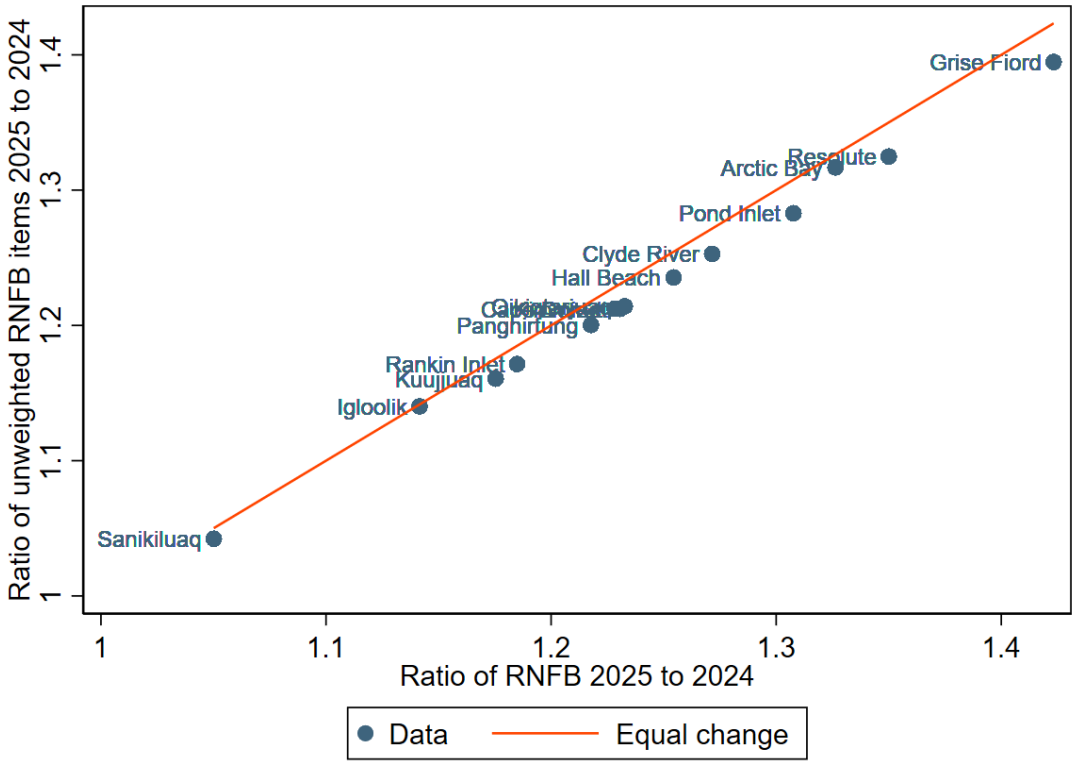
For the Northern Shopper, we match a much smaller share of products, so it is difficult to make direct comparisons to RNFB costs. We only match 25 products, accounting for about 16 out of 51.8 KG of RNFB weight.

In early 2026 we also began collecting data on all product prices from these companies and also Arctic Buying Company, which sells to the seven communities in the Kivalliq region as well as Gjoa Haven and Taloyoak in the Kitikmeot region and Arctic Bay, Igloolik, Iqaluit, Pond Inlet, Sanikiluak and Sanirajak in the Qikiqtaaluk region. Arctic Buying Company also reports delivered prices and separate measures of shipping and handling, insurance, and NNC subsidy. We are still in the process of collecting and analyzing these data for the purpose of tracking inflation and its components (in terms of base prices, freight costs and subsidies), but these are likely to be valuable data going forward as they provide a large set of product prices to compare over time. They also allow for simple comparison of base prices and delivered prices and the relative contribution of freight costs and subsidies. However, our analysis for Arctic Fresh highlights that these online prices can diverge substantially from local prices for the same set of products.

1.4.3 Price Analysis

Figure 8 reports the price change we observed between early 2024 and mid/late 2025 for Arctic Fresh, expressed as a ratio (i.e., 1.3 means prices rose 30%). On the x-axis we report the (RNFB) weighted estimates, and on the y-axis, we report the unweighted estimates.

Figure 8: Arctic Fresh Price Increases: RNFB-Weighted vs. Unweighted



These figures imply substantial inflation in this most recent period and wide variation across communities. Inflation appears to be higher when using RNFB weights, although this is not informative about the true cost-of-living (which requires using actual expenditure or quantity weights).

Figure 9 compares March 2024 RNFB prices from NNC to our estimates for Arctic Fresh. The correlation is not very strong but for most communities the Arctic Fresh cost is well above the local cost (Kimmirut is a notable exception). The higher cost of using Southern suppliers like Arctic Fresh helps explain why a relatively small share of NNC subsidized shipments comes from Southern suppliers and most subsidized shipments are shipped by local retailers.

Figure 10 reports inflation rates for Northern Shopper over the 2024-2025 period, using either RNFB weighting or the actual product weights themselves. The range of price increases is similar, and as with Arctic Fresh it appears that inflation is higher using RNFB weights than using the unweighted total.

Figure 9: Arctic Fresh vs. NNC RNFB Costs by Community

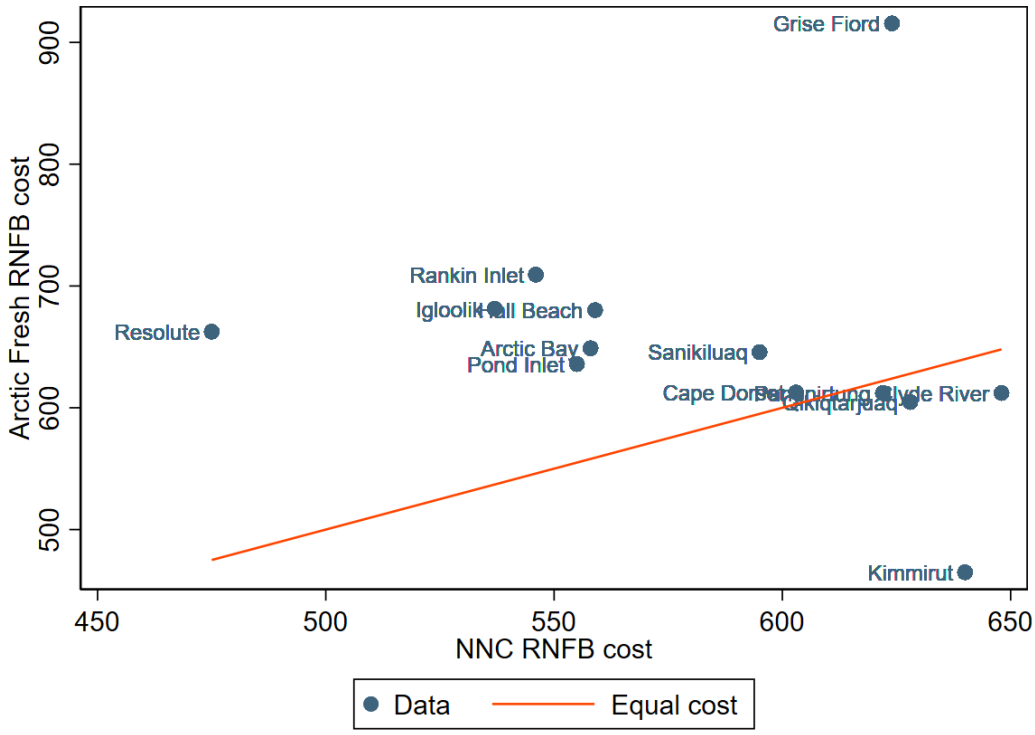
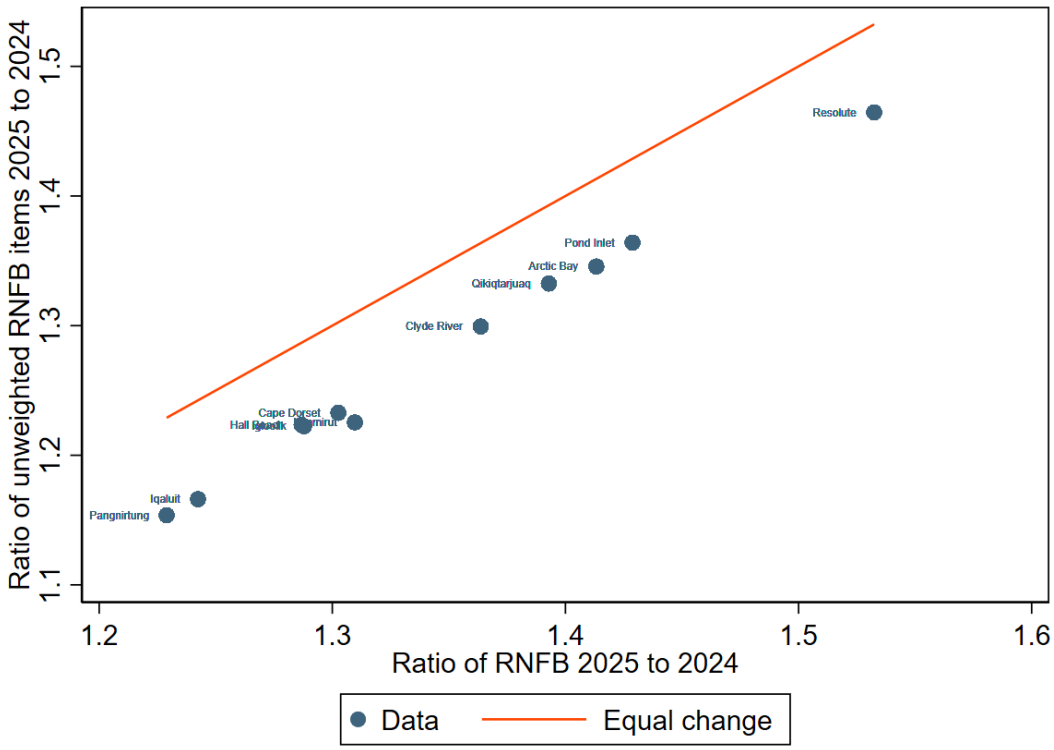


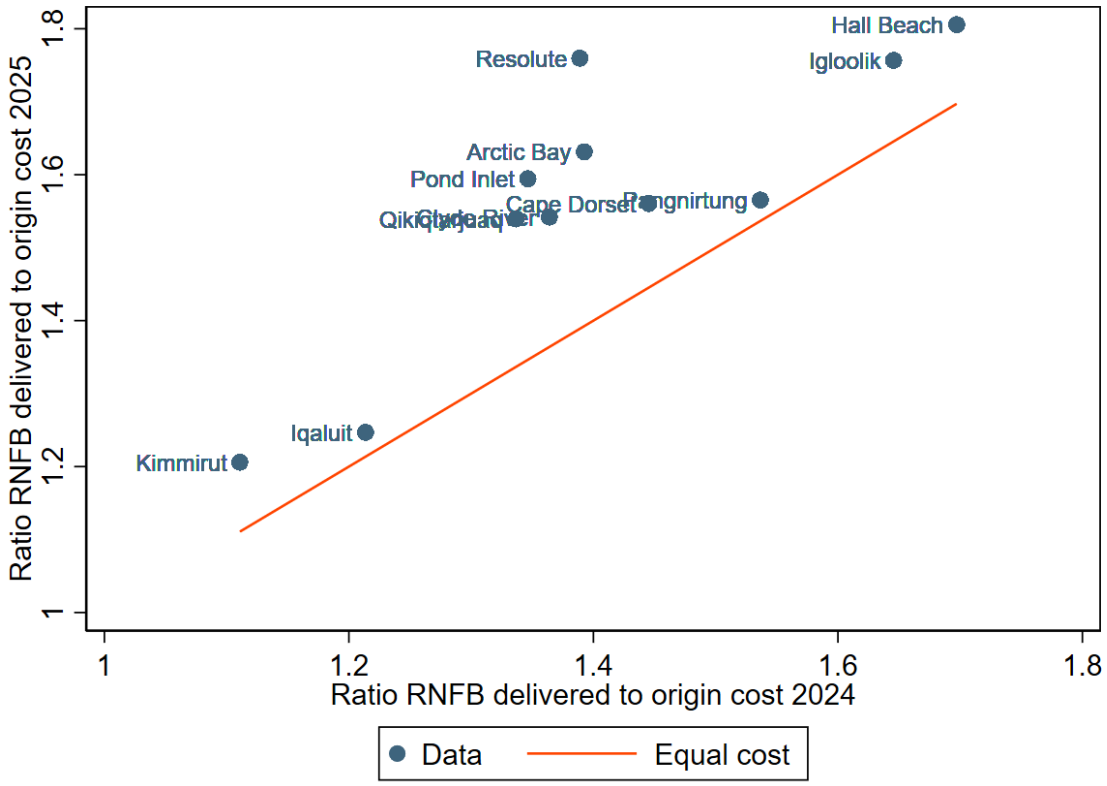
Figure 10: Northern Shopper Price Increases: RNFB-Weighted vs. Unweighted



Although the Northern Shopper data we collected makes comparison of RNFB costs in levels impossible due to missing data for most products, it has the advantage of including base prices at the origin (where the price is identical for all communities) with the delivered cost net of freight, insurance, and applied NNC subsidy. This gives us something like the price ratios calculated earlier, although the base price of the product need not correspond to an actual retail price in the South.

Figure 11 shows price ratios from about 1.2 to 1.8, varying substantially across communities and generally increasing over time, highlighting the erosion of the NNC subsidy rates (which did not change during this period) relative to freight costs (which did).

Figure 11: Northern Shopper Price Ratios



1.5 Other sources of cost-of-living data

1.5.1 Summary of findings

We are aware of two other sources of cost-of-living data that could potentially be used to track cost-of-living differences over time and across communities: the Isolated Post Allowances Index, and the Market Basket Measure. These measures are more comprehensive than the data considered above and include more than food. The Isolated Post Allowances index also makes some attempt to weight prices by expenditure patterns. These measures suggest that cost-of-living in Nunavut relative to the rest of Canada has increased since 2016 with the most recent data for 2023 showing 70%-101% higher prices depending on the region. These data also highlight persistent regional differences, with Kivalliq exhibiting the lowest price and Qikiqtaaluk (excluding Iqaluit) showing the highest prices.

1.5.2 Isolated Post Allowances Index (IPAI)

The Isolated Post Allowances Index (IPAI) is calculated by Statistics Canada and the National Joint Council, a body involved in negotiations around compensation

for civil servants.[12] The IPAI is the document that details the additional compensation that federal employees receive for being posted in remote locations. It has three components, one of which – the Living Cost Differential (LCD) – is specifically meant to capture a spatial price index for remote communities relative to comparison cities (Vancouver, Edmonton, Saskatoon, Winnipeg, Toronto, Montreal or St. John's). All communities with at least a 15% higher price are eligible for this allowance and the basket of goods includes food consumed at home as well as other categories (food away from home, household supplies and services, personal care, tobacco and alcohol, etc.). It excludes housing. Prices are collected for 250 products in total, and the individual prices are available on a confidential basis through Statistics Canada Research Data Centres; our analysis focuses on the public tabulations. Importantly, products are weighted based on the expenditures of the average Canadian family on these goods, so the spatial price differences captured are approximately representative of the cost-of-living.

While all Nunavut communities are included in this index, the Living Cost Differential (LCD) component is updated infrequently, such that the most recent data as of the October 2025 release is from 2019 and the index was only updated two additional times since 2003 (in 2007 and 2016). Nevertheless, if/when newer data is provided this will be a useful reference – while it lacks the granular detail or food focus of data we have considered to this point, it has the advantage of being more comprehensive while also attempting to weight different products by their (Canadian average) importance in the household budget.

1.5.3 Market Basket Measure

An alternative estimate, also derived by Statistics Canada, is the Market Basket Measure (MBM). This is a poverty line meant to capture the income required to purchase a basket of goods and services to meet basic needs. It is calculated on a spatial basis in Canada and updated with CPI inflation estimates. Statistics Canada recently developed an index for Nunavut and estimated spatial cost differences for four regions in Nunavut (the official regions but separating Iqaluit from the rest of Qikiqtaaluk). There are some changes in the estimates for Nunavut (e.g. they use a two adult three child family instead of a two adult two child family in the rest of Canada) such that direct comparisons with the

[12] Note that the Government of Nunavut also has a "Northern Allowance" paid to its employees, but the spatial price data used to determine the variation across communities and the time it was collected is unclear.

rest of Canada should be interpreted with caution. Nevertheless, the ratio of this index for Nunavut relative to another Canadian region or city is informative about spatial cost-of-living differences for 2023 when these were calculated and are the most comprehensive estimate of living costs available, encompassing all categories of goods and services (including housing and energy/utility costs, which are explicitly excluded from the LCD). Unlike the IPAI LCD, the food component of the MBM is based on a normative theoretical food basket (similar to the RNFB) called the National Nutritious Food Basket, making it less representative of cost differences for actual consumption patterns.

1.5.4. Price analysis

Table 6 presents estimates of relative costs for Nunavut overall and the three regions of Nunavut plus Iqaluit derived from these data, on a population-weighted basis (using 2021 census population counts). The relative cost-of-living implied by the LCD index was 1.64 in 2007 and stable through 2016, but in 2019 had risen to 1.7 due to large increases in Qikiqtaaluk and Iqaluit. The Market Basket Measure in 2023 shows even higher ratios – 1.85 overall for Nunavut and higher within each region. There is some agreement between these measures – Qikiqtaaluk is the most expensive region, Kivalliq the cheapest, and Kitikmeot in the middle – although Iqaluit is an outlier in that it is somewhat cheaper than average according to the LCD and the most expensive community according to the MBM. It is unclear why we see this divergence, but we suspect housing costs (which are

incorporated in the MBM, but excluded from the LCD) play an important role as food and most traded goods may be cheaper but housing more expensive in Iqaluit.

Table 6. Living Cost Differentials and Market Basket Measure

Region	Living Cost Differential 2007	Living Cost Differential 2016	Living Cost Differential 2019	Market Basket Measure 2023
Nunavut	1.64	1.63	1.70	1.85
Qikiqtaaluk (excluding Iqaluit)	1.62	1.61	1.80	1.90
Kivalliq	1.69	1.66	1.61	1.70
Kitikmeot	1.72	1.73	1.73	1.83
Iqaluit	1.53	1.53	1.68	2.01

Note: Population-weighted estimates. The Living Cost Differential excludes housing; the Market Basket Measure includes housing and energy and uses a different reference family for Nunavut.

2. Assessing factors that contribute to inflation and high relative prices

The price of a food product in Nunavut can be theoretically broken down into three components:

Nunavut Price = Product wholesale cost + Freight cost - NNC subsidy + Gross Margin.

In this accounting identity, the gross margin must cover all other relevant costs that are not inherent to the product (labour, energy, capital, management/corporate services) and if these costs could be measured at the product level, we could further derive a "net margin" or pure profit measure. In practice such measures of "pure" profit are only observed at a more aggregate level (e.g. retailers measure these costs at the store or corporate division rather than allocating them to individual products) and retailers typically use sophisticated pricing strategies focused on maximizing this aggregate "pure" profit that allow for interactions across products (e.g. they may have "loss-leaders" with zero or even negative gross margins, if this can help drive up margins on other products).

Neither the product wholesale cost nor the actual freight cost paid by the retailer are directly observable to us. The former reflects wholesale pricing, and the latter involves supply chain logistics, bulk discounts, and potentially vertically integrated and/or unobserved additional freight costs (e.g. truck transportation from warehouses to ports and from ports to stores).

However, we do observe proxies for these components. We can observe retail prices in the South for many products as we saw in Section 1 of this report. Southern retail prices include both wholesale product prices as well as Southern gross margins. Observed aggregate gross margins in the industry (considered in section 2.4) imply that a large share of retail prices are accounted for by the cost of goods sold.

We observe publicly posted freight costs for many important freight carriers serving Nunavut in recent years – Canadian North (serving Qikiqtaaluk and Kitikmeot) and Calm Air (serving Kivalliq), and the two sealift/resupply companies

(Desgagnes Transarctik, and NEAS). These freight costs are likely to be an upper bound for what large retailers pay, as they may negotiate bulk discounts or use charters and/or their own planes when this is cheaper, but they are still likely to be informative; if larger retailers secure constant percentage discounts (e.g. 50% of the posted price) then observed increases in freight cost are still accurate measures of freight cost inflation rates, and we would generally expect a strong correlation. We also observe the freight costs charged to customers for some online stores (NNC registered Southern suppliers) that ship to Nunavut.

We can observe the NNC subsidies that are applied to a product. These are likely the most precisely measured component of a product's price, although there are measurement challenges related to classification of products, the timing of subsidy application given inventory lags, transportation mode for non-perishable products.

Corporate reports are available for the North West Company that provide insight into the evolution of gross and net profit margins, and some data are available from Arctic Co-operatives (albeit less informative data given the structure and varied businesses of the Co-ops). Stock prices are also potentially informative about profitability although these are theoretically a forward-looking predictor of profits rather than an indicator of current or past profit levels.

Thus, in practice, we can – for some specific products and time periods – break down prices into some combination of the following terms:

Nunavut Price = South price + Freight cost proxy – NNC subsidy + "Gross margin differential."

The "gross margin differential" here captures many unobserved factors including differences between observed proxies and actual freight cost, differences in negotiated wholesale costs, and differences in both gross margin and net margin between Southern and Northern retail. If the gross margin differential is negative, it simply means that an individual cannot achieve a lower price by purchasing a product at retail price in the South and shipping it to Nunavut (with NNC subsidy applied) -- local retailers can still have a positive gross margin if their actual freight costs and wholesale costs are lower than our proxies.

2.1 Freight cost

2.1.1 Summary of findings

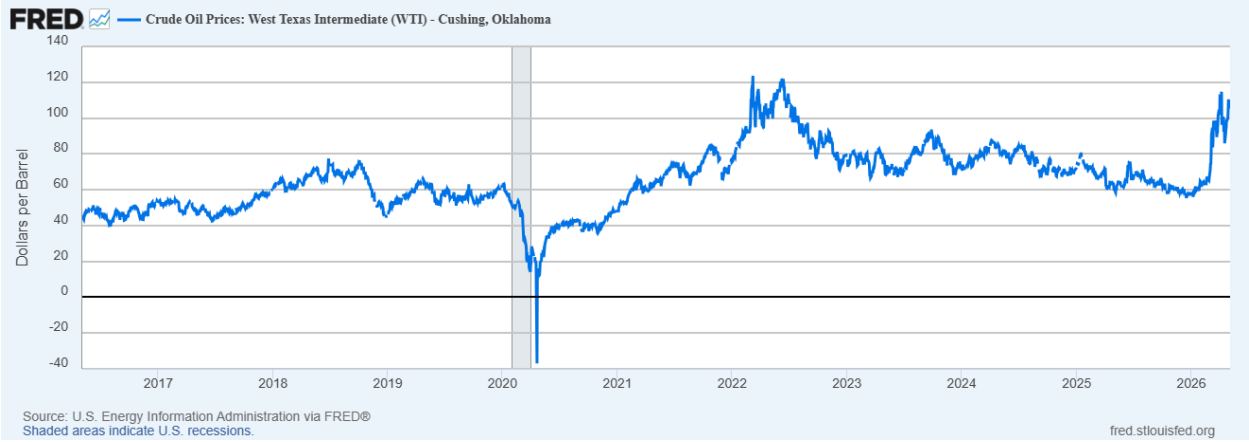
Publicly available freight cost data shows a large increase in freight costs for air and ocean freight, in the range of 20-25% (since 2021) for air freight and 25-30% (since 2019) for ocean freight. The timing and magnitude of

increases largely tracks a Canadian freight index reported by Statistics Canada (combining all modes including trucks). Ocean freight largely tracks a US ocean freight index, but air freight remained elevated even as oil prices and US air freight costs declined relative to the peak in late 2022. These increases in freight costs exceed Canadian Food CPI inflation over similar periods (25.7% since 2019, 20.8% since 2021).

2.1.2 Air freight

Data on air freight come from the Canadian North and Calm Air. We focus on the standard freight rates and define the origin port as Edmonton for Kitikmeot, Winnipeg for Kivalliq and Ottawa for Qikiqtaaluk. In recent years, the rise in oil prices since 2021 was an important catalyst for changes in freight costs as shown in Figure 12. However, other factors including labour costs, capital and maintenance costs were also likely important. Changes in the market environment may also have played a role – recent developments include the acquisition of North Star Airlines by the North West Company in 2017 and its subsequent expansion into Manitoba, the Canadian North – First Air merger in 2019[13], and the acquisition of Canadian North by the Exchange Income Corporation (which also owns Calm Air) in 2025.

Figure 12: West Texas Intermediate (WTI) Crude Oil Prices, 2017–2026



[13] The Canadian North – First Air merger was subject to a number of terms and conditions related to pricing and profits, see https://www.canada.ca/en/transport-canada/news/2019/06/government-of-canada-approves-first-air-and-canadian-north-merger.html. These were amended in 2023, see https://www.canada.ca/en/transport-canada/news/2023/04/government-of-canada-and-canadian-north-agree-on-new-terms-and-conditions-of-airline-merger.html

Figure 13: Changes in Air Freight Costs by Region, 2021–2026

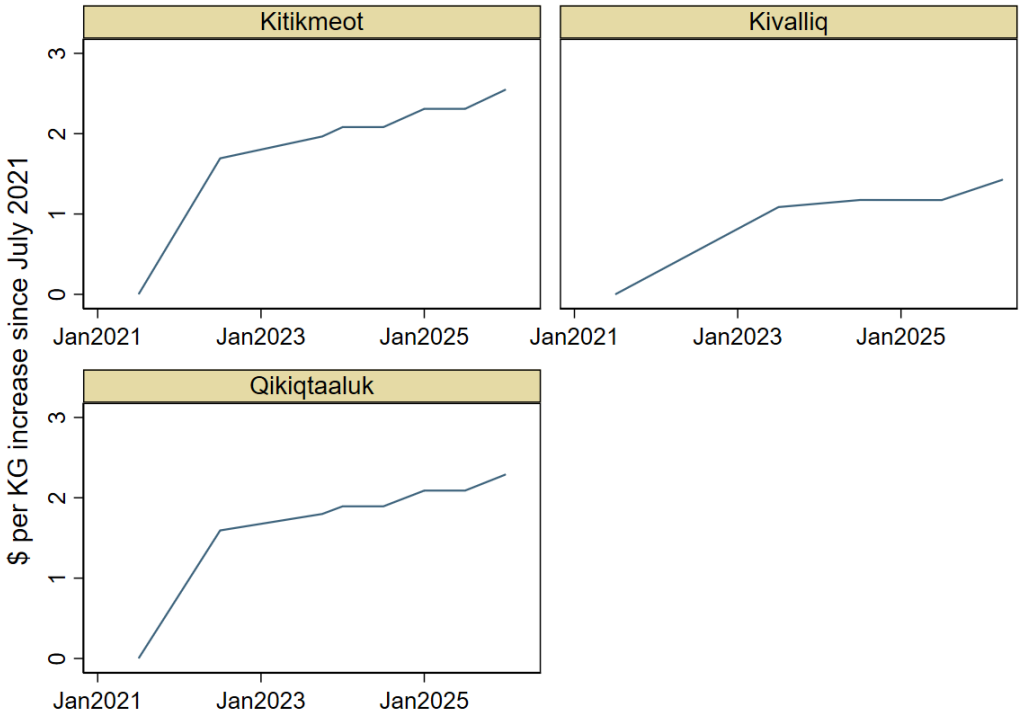
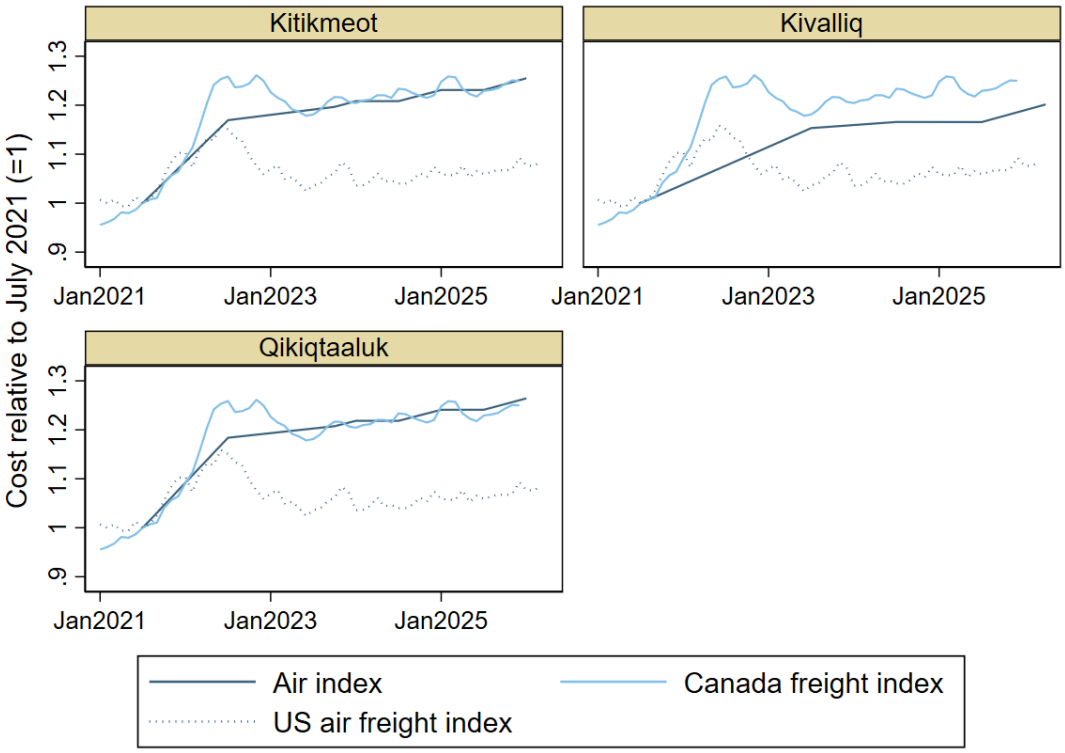


Figure 13 reports changes in population-weighted average freight prices per kilogram for each region since 2021. There is a notable surge from 2021 to early 2023 followed by a slow steady increase.

We can compare these freight cost changes to two Southern comparators: the Canadian freight index constructed by Statistics Canada that includes air freight but also truck/ocean, and a US Air freight index. We report this in Figure 14, which shows that our Northern Air freight index rose over 20% in every region since January 2021 with the smallest increase in Kivalliq. This is similar to overall Canadian freight inflation (which is above Kivalliq inflation) but significantly greater than US air freight inflation. US air freight rose by a similar magnitude during the peak of oil prices in late 2022 (following the Russian invasion of Ukraine) but later declined. It is difficult to be certain what caused this divergence, but one hypothesis is that airlines in Northern Canada increased their profits relative to US air freight carriers) during this period; this need not imply "excess" profits, especially if these airlines were operating at a loss at the beginning of the period.[14]

[14] This hypothesis is consistent with the Government of Canada's revised Terms and Conditions of the First-Air Canadian North merger which allows the airline to raise prices up

Figure 14: Air Freight Cost Trends



2.1.3 Sealift/resupply freight

We can do a similar analysis using data on sealift/resupply rates. These data are available since 2019 from the websites of Desgagnes Transarctik and NEAS and are expressed in dollars per revenue ton. Although some communities are served by both companies in some years, the prices are similar, so there is effectively one price per season; Kivalliq communities have access to multiple origin ports (one in Quebec for the Hudson Strait route, and one in Churchill) and we report data for Churchill here.

to 25% annually and "to recoup past losses over a 3-year period" https://www.canada.ca/en/transport-canada/news/2023/04/government-of-canada-and-canadian-north-agree-on-new-terms-and-conditions-of-airline-merger.html.
For Calm Air, the Annual Report of the Exchange Income Corporation indicates stable EBITDA and net earnings margins between 2021 and 2025 (and stable EBITDA margins for the aviation division) but there is no separate reporting for Calm Air.

Figure 15: Changes in Sealift Costs by Region, 2019–2025

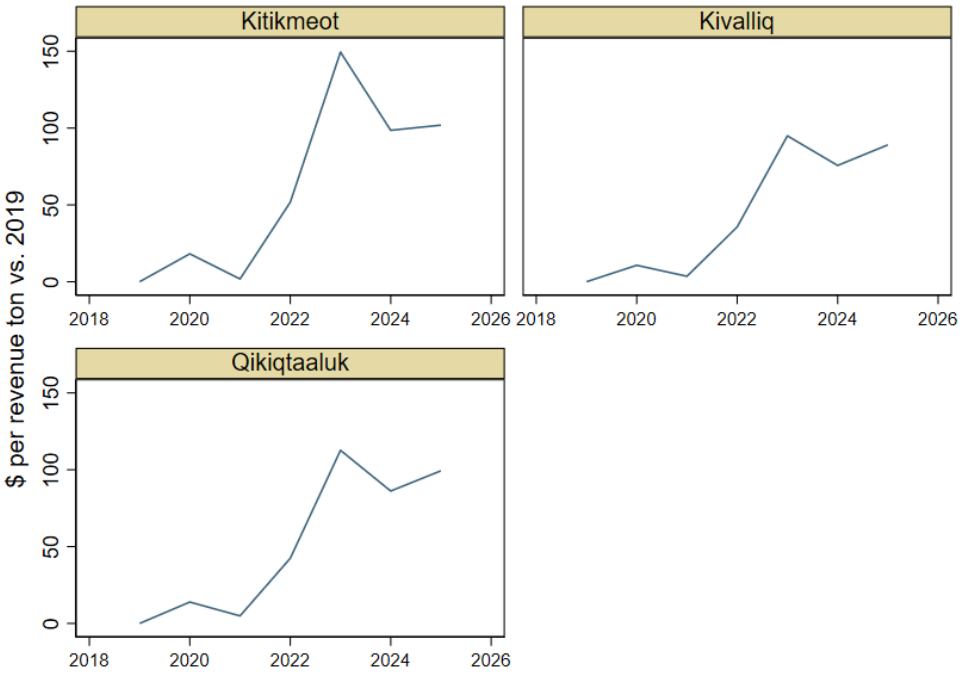
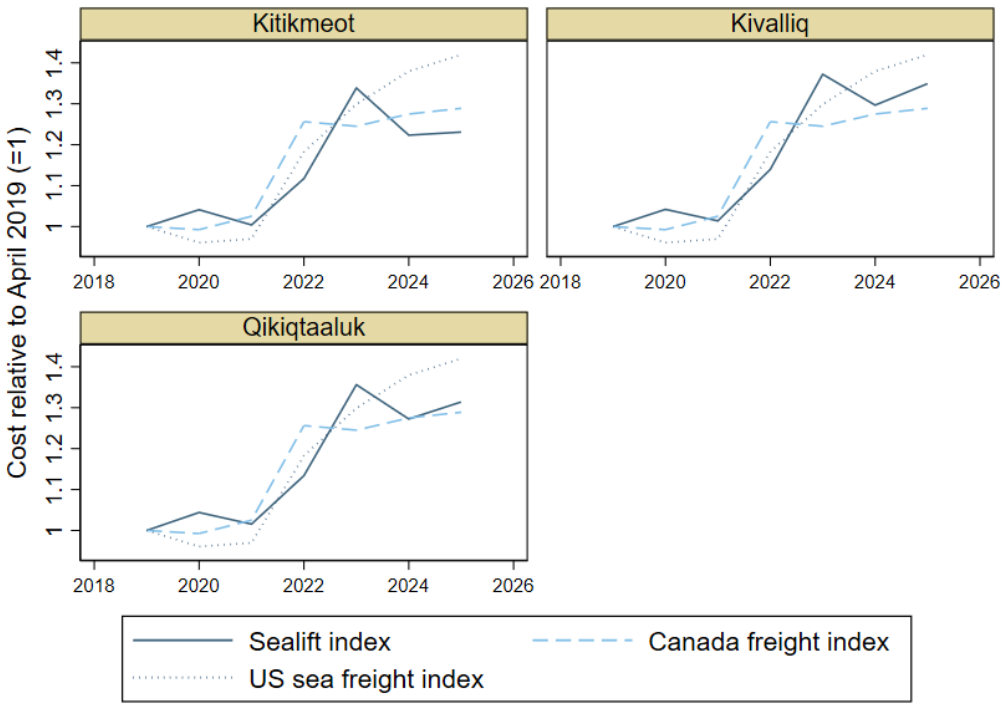


Figure 16: Sealift Cost Trends



As shown in the Figures 15 and 16, we observe large increases between 2021-2022 and especially 2022-2023, followed by some decline. The pattern is similar across regions although the magnitudes differ somewhat. We find a peak representing more than a 30% increase and a similar increse over the whole period. Overall, the increase is similar to the change in the Canadian overall freight cost index over the same period (slightly lower in Kitikmeot and slightly higher in Kivalliq) and lower than the US sea freight index.

2.2 NNC subsidies

2.2.1 Summary of findings

An analysis of NNC subsidies versus air freight costs suggests that current (May 2026) NNC subsidy levels are well below freight costs for every community, even for the most subsidized products. This helps account for the large price gaps we documented earlier. Recent changes in NNC subsidy rates have not kept up with the increased freight costs, helping to explain why we see "excess" inflation in Nunavut in recent years.

2.2.2. Analysis

In this section, we compare current NNC subsidy rates with freight costs and examine how both have changed over time. For both air and sea freight, freight charges are generally calculated using the higher of a weight-based or volume-based measure. For food shipped by air, the weight-based charge is usually higher, which allows us to directly compare freight costs per kilogram with NNC subsidies, which are also calculated per kilogram. For sea freight, the volume-based charge is generally more important, making a direct comparison with the weight-based NNC subsidy more difficult. For this reason, and the fact that most of the NNC subsidy is applied to air freight, the analysis below focuses on air freight. As before, we use Canadian North standard freight from Ottawa for Qikiqtaaluk, from Edmonton for Kitikmeot, and use Calm Air standard freight from Winnipeg for Kivalliq.

In terms of changes, we only have air freight back to early 2021,[15] but we can plot this change in air freight against both the change in subsidies since then (a 5%/3%/40% increase in high/medium/low subsidy rates that occurred in February 2023). We also

[15] Given that cargo rates were frozen in 2019 as part of the terms and conditions of the First Air - Canadian North merger approval, large increases in freight costs before 2021 are less likely but we cannot rule them out with the data available to us. See https://www.canada.ca/en/transport-canada/news/2019/06/government-of-canada-approves-first-air-and-canadian-north-merger.html

consider a more expansive estimate of NNC subsidy changes that includes subsidy rate changes that took effect in January 2019 (a large increase for certain items when the new “high subsidy” rate was introduced) and May 2020 (when there was a large increase in the “medium subsidy” rate, which makes up the largest share of all NNC subsidized products and is the most important in dollar terms).

Figure 17 shows the current NNC subsidy rates (in effect since February 2023) compared to air freight (from early 2026). Each dot represents a specific subsidy level (high, medium or low) for a community. The dots are well below the 45-degree line (which indicates subsidy equal to air freight) implying that subsidies are lower than air freight. This is true in every Nunavut community and for the highest subsidy rates, and the difference is large given the y and x axis scales.

Figure 17: NNC Subsidies and Air Freight Costs

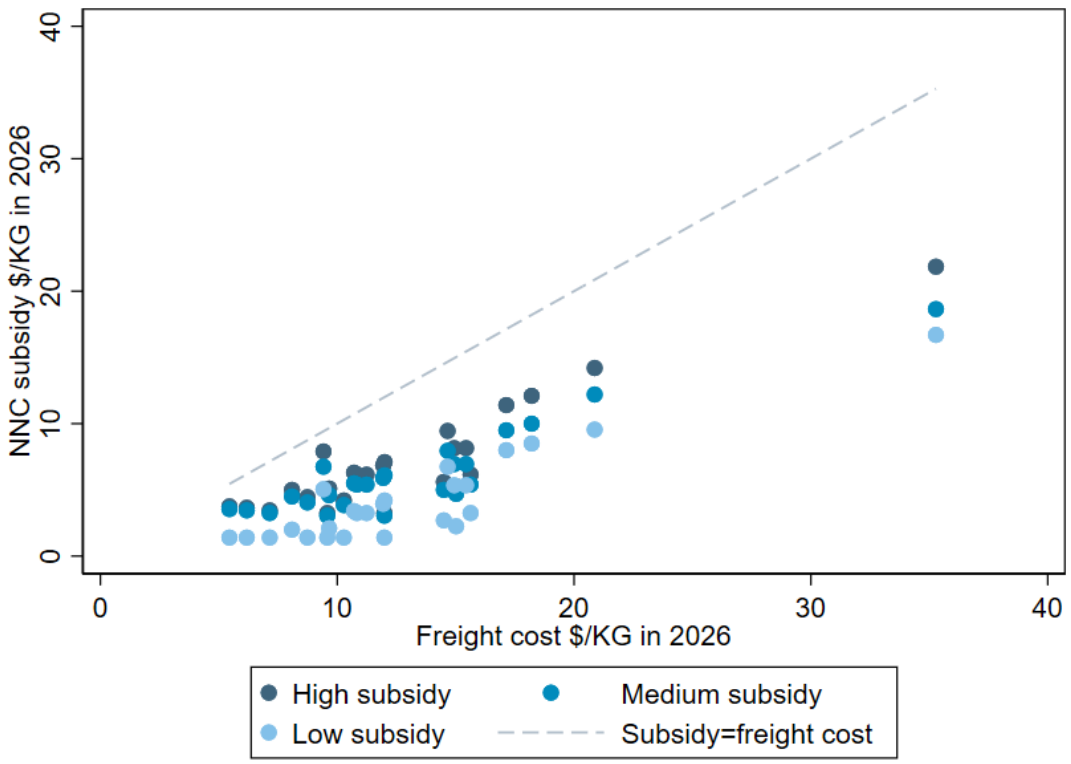


Figure 18 shows the changes in NNC also fall well short of the changes in freight costs, implying that Nunavut communities experienced increased freight net of NNC subsidies for subsidized foods.

Figure 19 shows that, taking a longer-term perspective (and ignoring possible changes in air freight from December 2018 to 2021), increases in NNC subsidy rates for products classified as high subsidy (fresh milk, infant foods and frozen fruits/vegetables) are close to (and in a few cases exceeding) changes in freight rates, but other subsidy increases still fall well short.

Whether the change in observed freight cost and NNC subsidies actually translates into price changes depends on additional factors, such as whether our observed freight costs accurately cover cost changes for retailers, and whether changes in freight cost and NNC subsidies are passed through to consumers.

Figure 18: Changes in NNC Subsidies Compared with Air Freight Costs Since 2021

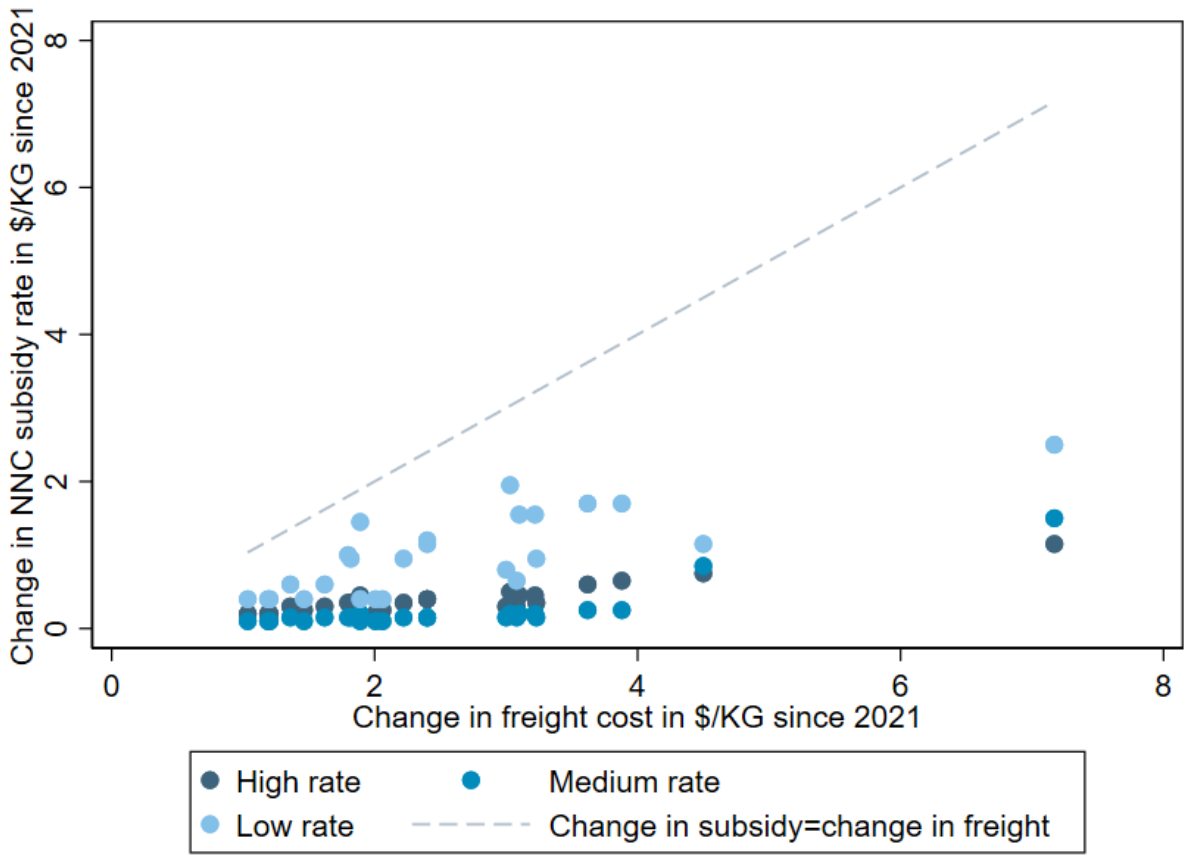
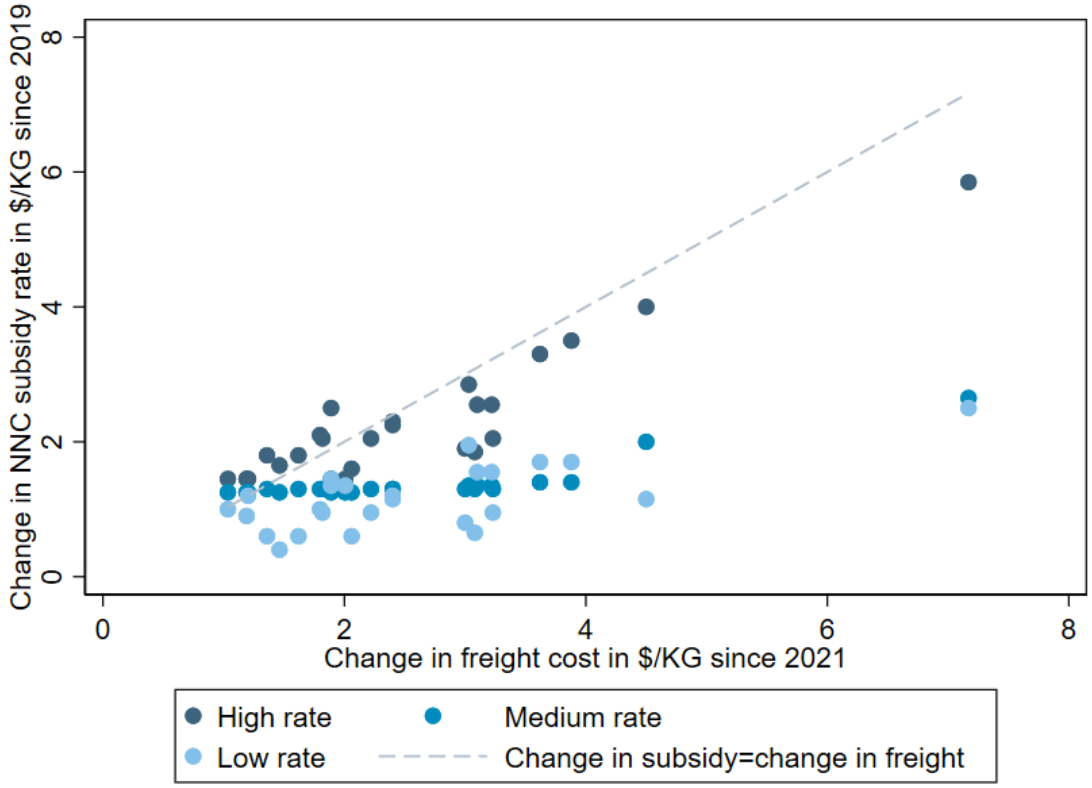


Figure 19: Longer-Term Changes in NNC Subsidies Compared with Air Freight Costs



2.3 Effect of the ICFI Hamlet Food Voucher Program

High inflation in Nunavut occurred within a few years of the adoption of the ICFI Hamlet Voucher program, which provided a substantial infusion of purchasing power when adopted ($6,000 annually per Inuit child, $9,000 per Inuit child aged 3 and under, equivalent to $2,400 per capita). Communities adopted the program at different times between July 2023 and March 2025, when the program ended. Sinha et al. (2026) provide an exhaustive evaluation of the program. Here we consider whether the program affected prices, given that the high inflation documented earlier occurred around the time of program adoption and many community members perceived a connection.

2.3.1 Summary of findings

Price data from ICFI and the RNFB indicate that most inflation occurred in the period before the first community adopted the program in July 2023. Comparing communities that adopted the program earlier to those that adopted the program later, we cannot reject the hypothesis that there was zero average effect

on prices for the products we observe, and we can reject the hypothesis that the contribution to inflation was large relative to overall inflation since 2021.

2.3.2 Before vs. after

As seen in the Figure 5 from section 1.2, inflation measured in the ICFI individual voucher receipt data was much higher in the period from 2022-June 2023 – before any communities had adopted the Hamlet voucher program – than in the subsequent period.

The NNC RNFB data paint a similar picture. The vertical line denotes the timing of ICFI Hamlet voucher adoption for the communities that adopted the program, with earlier adopters in the first two rows and the last adopters in the last row. Figure 20 illustrates that some communities experienced small price increases, decreases, or no change subsequent to the introduction of the program, but that most of the price increase occurred during earlier periods.

Figure 20: RNFB Price Trends Before and After HFV Adoption

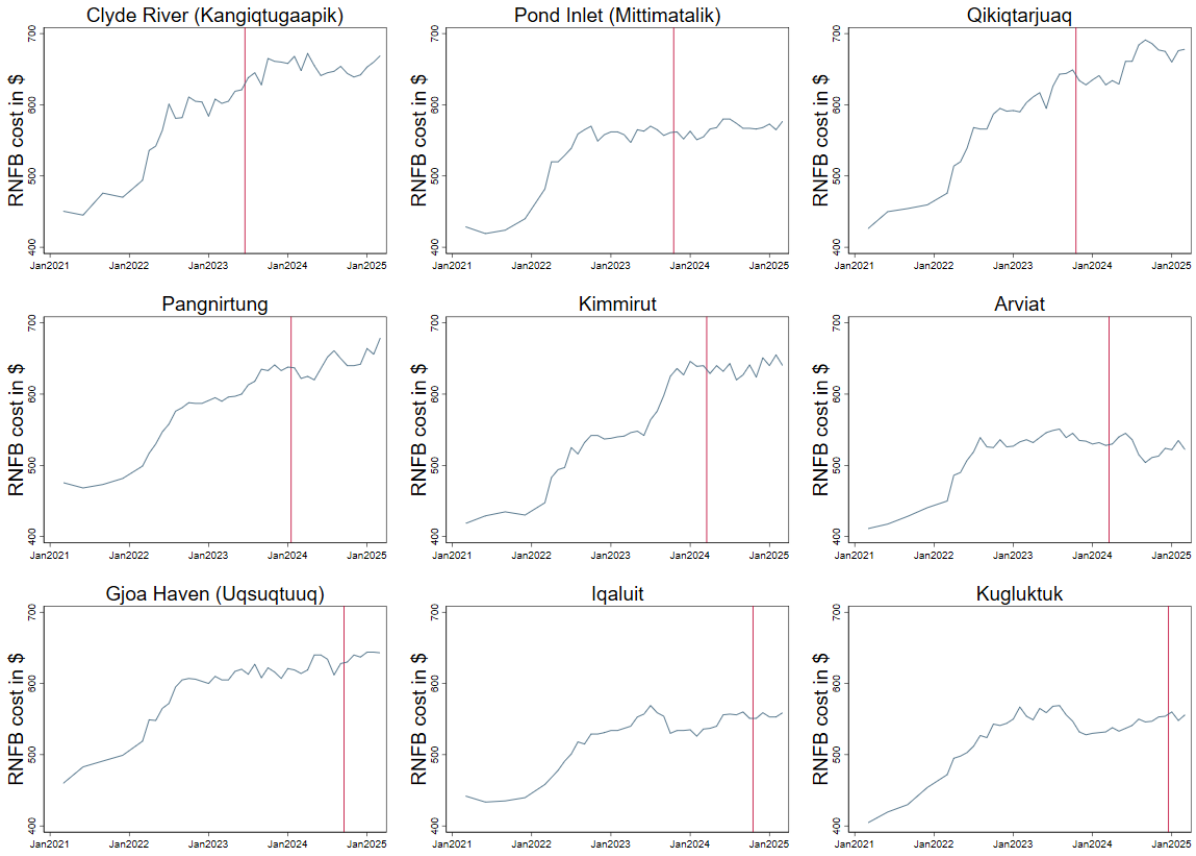
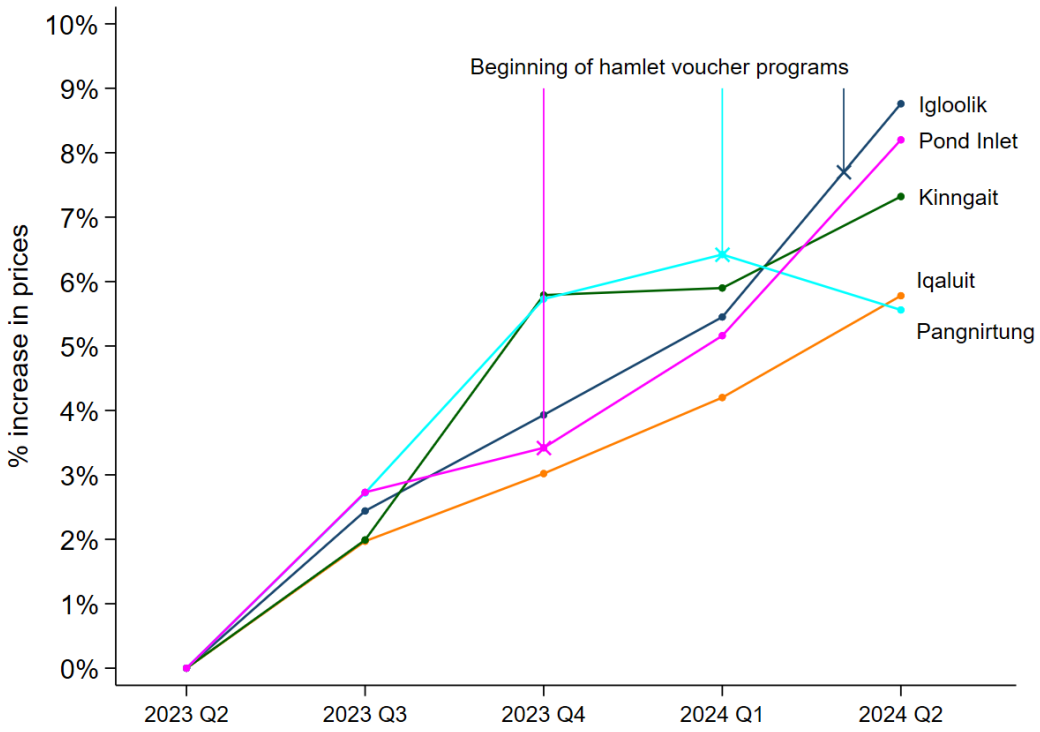


Figure 21: Price Trends in Early and Later Adopting HFV Communities



2.3.3 Comparing early versus late adopters

To investigate this more formally, we estimate a two-way fixed effects regression – an implementation of the "difference-in-difference" econometric framework – that essentially compares the trajectory of prices in Nunavut communities that have not received the Hamlet voucher program (the "control group") to communities that have received it. This methodology is illustrated by the following figure reported in Sinha et al. (2025). Figure 21 shows that prices in communities that had the voucher program increased at about the same rate as prices in communities that didn't have it. We used statistical analyses to compare inflation (the increase in prices) after the voucher program started in Kinngait, Igloolik, and Pangnirtung to the hamlets which had not yet started food voucher programs.

Because the program was phased in a staggered fashion, several communities received the program before the end of current data sets (the ICFI has good coverage until June 2024, by which point 8 Qikiqtaaluk communities had received the program, and the RNFB data extends to March 2025, by

which point 24 Nunavut communities had received the program). The model allows for common inflation trends – driven by the types of freight cost increases and Southern retail price increases observed earlier – and attributes any "excess" inflation that occurs after the introduction of the program to the program itself. We report the results in Table 7.

Although there is limited sample size and variation, the estimates imply only small effects on prices that are not statistically different than zero, ranging from 0.1-0.3% for the ICFI data and 0.8-1.3% for the RNFB data.

The magnitudes for RNFB data are in the ballpark of the estimated effects of the 2016 Child Benefit expansion in Daley, Li, and Watson (2025). Given the statistical uncertainty associated with our estimates, we cannot reject a modest contribution to inflation (ranging from 1.3% using the ICFI data and as high as 3.6% using the RNFB data) but these magnitudes, which represent the upper bound of plausible price effects given our data, are still small relative to the common price increases that occurred for all Nunavut communities over this period.

Table 7. Estimated effect of HFV adoption on average prices

Measure	ICFI 2022 Q1-2024 Q2	ICFI 2023 Q2-2024 Q2	NNC RNFB Apr. 2022-Mar. 2025 25 communities	NNC RNFB Apr. 2022-Mar. 2025 21 communities
Price effect (0.01 = 1%)	0.003	0.001	0.008	0.013
p-value for the null hypothesis of no effect	0.488	0.703	0.507	0.263
95% confidence interval	[-0.006, 0.013]	[-0.007, 0.011]	[-0.016, 0.030]	[-0.011, 0.036]
Communities	13	13	25	21
Observations	315,585	288,168	828	756
Treated communities	8	8	24	21

Note: Two-way fixed-effects estimates. The ICFI specifications include store-UPC and month fixed effects; the NNC specifications include community and month fixed effects. p-values and confidence intervals use a wild cluster bootstrap with Webb weights.

This analysis has three important limitations. First, we estimate effects on *average* prices for a specific basket of goods, such that the program may still have resulted in large price increases for specific products (and may equally have resulted in large price decreases for some products). Second, the baskets we consider exclude many products, including "luxuries" that would be prime candidates for higher markups when consumers have more money spend. Third, we have limited information on "after" prices for late adopting communities, particularly in the ICFI data that captures a larger set of products. As more data RNFB is released we may be able to assess whether the termination of the program in March 2025 had any effect on subsequent prices.

2.4 Retailer margins

2.4.1 Summary of findings

Annual reports provide insight into the evolution of margins over time, although they should be interpreted with caution given the complexities of corporate accounting and our inability to directly measure margins for the food products or specific Nunavut stores whose prices we analyze in this report. These reports suggest that margins are unlikely to account for *most* of the increase in food prices over this period, or the excess inflation documented for Nunavut. However, we do observe increases in margins and profitability since 2018, and inflation would have been lower if retailers had maintained constant margins and lower still if retailers had lowered their margins to absorb some of the cost increases (which could still be consistent with constant or rising profits). The North West Company appears to be the highest margin food retailer among the major Canadian retailers, which plausibly contributes to the high price ratios we observe. Taken at face value, these data suggest an upper bound on the contribution of margins to higher inflation and higher price levels in Nunavut of about 5% for this period.

2.4.2 Detailed analysis

Table 8 presents financial data from the Annual Reports of the North West Company, Arctic Co-Operatives Ltd., and three leading Canadian food retailers (Loblaws, Metro and Empire). Gross revenue is all sales, the gross margin is revenue minus the cost of goods sold divided as a share of gross revenue, and the net margin is the net earnings (essentially profits) as a share of gross revenue.

It shows that the North West Company has higher gross and net margins than the other retailers in virtually every year. Margins have increased since 2018 with some ups and downs; net margins in particular peaked in 2021 and declined after that, but remain higher than the pre-

pandemic period. The timing of the increase is earlier than the inflation we observe in freight costs and RNFB prices, and could be related to multiple factors (NNC subsidy increases in 2019 and 2020, pandemic effects and government responses, divestment of 36 Giant Tiger stores in 2020).

Note that these margin calculations include many stores outside of Canada and over a hundred stores in Canada but outside of Nunavut, so should not be interpreted as precise measures of margins from Nunavut stores. However, the most recent reported EBITDA margins for the Canadian stores (15.2%) are substantially higher than those for the international division (9.6%) and Southern retailers which ranged from 7-10% in 2025. The EBITDA margins for Canadian operations rose from 10.4% to 16.7% between 2018 and 2021 before declining to 15.2% by 2025, with a similar increase for the earnings margin.

Arctic Co-op is hard to compare given its different objectives, accounting, and varied businesses outside of retail, but the margin/profit-like outcomes it reports show less evidence of increasing over time. Arctic Co-op operates many non-retail businesses (e.g. hotels, restaurants) that are included in these figures.

Other Canadian retailers increased their margins by similar magnitudes during this period, but Loblaws has outperformed the other retailers. All retailers outperformed the Canadian stock market substantially over this period, with Loblaws the clear winner.

Put in this broader Canadian context, the North West Company is not exceptional among food retailers in increasing it margins and profitability in the last 8 years, but stands out as having the highest gross and net margin among these retailers as of 2025, particularly for its Canadian operations.

Table 8. Selected retailer financial indicators, 2018-2025

Retailer / indicator	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
North West Company								
Gross revenue (millions)	2,013	2,094	2,359	2,249	2,353	2,472	2,576	2,598
Gross margin	31.8%	31.7%	32.8%	32.8%	31.8%	32.8%	33.7%	33.9%
Net margin	4.5%	4.1%	6.1%	7.0%	5.4%	5.4%	5.6%	5.6%
Net earnings (millions)	91	86	144	157	126	134	143	146
Canadian sales (millions)	1,246	1,272	1,376	1,291	1,323	1,419	1,475	1,469
Canadian EBITDA/ sales	10.4%	11.0%	15.0%	16.7%	14.0%	14.4%	15.2%	15.2%
Canadian operating earnings / sales	5.9%	6.1%	10.5%	11.9%	9.0%	9.4%	10.0%	9.9%
Share price (TSE:NWC)	22.47	23.92	25.03	30.95	30.52	31.11	41.98	47.61
Share-price ratio versus mid-2018	1.00	1.06	1.11	1.38	1.36	1.38	1.87	2.12
Arctic Co-operatives Ltd.								
Gross revenue (millions)		247	265	300	318	338	341	339
Gross margin		13.4%	13.0%	12.3%	11.3%	12.4%	12.3%	12.5%
Central patronage allocation (millions)		9.2	10.8	10.0	7.7	9.3	8.4	11.5
Member dividend (millions)			13	19	18	16	13	17

Note: Figures are drawn from annual reports and historical share-price data. Blank cells indicate that the source table did not report a value for that year. Corporate reporting scopes differ, so comparisons should be interpreted cautiously.

Table 8. Selected retailer financial indicators, 2018-2025 (continued)

Retailer / indicator	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Loblaw Companies Ltd.								
Gross revenue (millions)	46,693	48,037	52,714	53,170	56,504	59,529	61,014	63,903
Gross margin	29.4%	29.7%	29.5%	30.7%	30.9%	31.0%	31.3%	31.3%
Net margin	1.7%	2.4%	2.3%	3.7%	3.5%	3.7%	3.7%	4.3%
Share price (TSE:L)	14.00	16.76	16.79	18.96	29.02	30.32	39.67	55.90
Share-price ratio versus mid-2018	1.00	1.20	1.20	1.35	2.07	2.17	2.83	3.99
Metro Inc.								
Gross revenue (millions)	14,384	16,768	17,998	18,283	18,889	20,725	21,220	22,007
Gross margin	19.7%	19.9%	19.9%	20.0%	20.0%	19.8%	19.7%	19.9%
Net margin	4.0%	4.4%	4.4%	4.5%	4.5%	4.9%	4.4%	4.6%
Share price (TSE:MRU)	44.22	49.53	56.07	59.89	70.18	73.09	75.80	106.18
Share-price ratio versus mid-2018	1.00	1.12	1.27	1.35	1.59	1.65	1.71	2.40

Note: Figures are drawn from annual reports and historical share-price data. Blank cells indicate that the source table did not report a value for that year. Corporate reporting scopes differ, so comparisons should be interpreted cautiously.

Table 8. Selected retailer financial indicators, 2018-2025 (continued)

Retailer / indicator	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Empire Company Ltd. (Sobeys)								
Gross revenue (millions)	24,215	25,142	26,588	28,268	30,162	30,478	31,277	30,733
Gross margin	25.1%	23.5%	24.9%	25.5%	25.4%	25.6%	26.3%	26.8%
Net margin	1.4%	1.6%	2.2%	2.5%	2.5%	2.4%	2.3%	2.3%
Share price (TSE:EMP.A)	26.51	33.56	32.48	39.86	40.43	36.86	34.97	56.13
Share-price ratio versus mid-2018	1.00	1.27	1.23	1.50	1.53	1.39	1.32	2.12
S&P/TSX Composite Index	16,372	16,488	15,597	20,226	19,023	20,262	21,876	26,692
TSX ratio versus mid-2018	1.00	1.01	0.95	1.24	1.16	1.24	1.34	1.63

Note: Figures are drawn from annual reports and historical share-price data. Blank cells indicate that the source table did not report a value for that year. Corporate reporting scopes differ, so comparisons should be interpreted cautiously.

2.5 Combined analysis

In this section we combine the data on freight costs, subsidy rates, and Southern product prices to provide some examples of the potential contribution of these factors to Nunavut prices, both in ratios (compared to Southern prices) and in terms of inflation (changes over time).

2.5.1. Summary of findings

Our examples highlight several patterns consistent with our analysis in earlier sections. Price ratios (versus the South) are higher for products with low value/weight (like produce) and lower subsidies, and have risen in recent years. Part of the increase in prices can be accounted for by rising prices in the South, and part can be explained by freight cost increases that exceed NNC subsidy increases. We consider two examples, where in one case the change in the "gross margin differential" is positive and another it is negative, highlighting the difficulty of inferring changes in retailer margins at the product level

using the data and methodology used in this report. Looking at larger bundles like the RNFB, we estimate that during the 2021-2025 period, freight costs (net of NNC subsidy increases) can account for about 33-52% of the increase in price, and Southern price increases can account for another 28%. This implies a 20-39% increase in the gross margin differential, which represents both changes in profits (relative to Southern retailers) but also changes in relative local costs or unobserved freight/wholesale costs.

2.5.2 Example basket using ICFI data

We begin with an example drawn from the ICFI data for a basic grocery basket consisting of 5 pounds of potatoes, one pound of carrots, 2 litres of 2% milk, 3 pounds of bananas and almost one pound of ground beef as shown in Table 9. These products all receive the medium NNC subsidy except for milk which receives the high NNC subsidy. We report the price a household paid in Kinngait, the average price for the same product in Canada, the NNC subsidy associated with the product, and the freight charged by Canadian North from Ottawa, for the first half of 2022 versus the first half of 2024. For the potatoes and milk we use BetterCart data for the same barcode, while for the other products we use the average price reported by Statistics Canada. In the third column we also include data from May 2026 from the Arctic Fresh website, which reports actual NNC and freight applied as well as a "base" price we associate with the Canadian price. In this case the local and base price are for the exact same product.

We summarize the total basket cost in the bottom rows. From 2022 to 2024, the Kinngait cost rose 31.7% while the Canada cost rose only 4.8%, such that the price ratio for the basket rose from 1.44 to 1.81. The price ratio was highest for produce and generally lower for meat and dairy, consistent with generally lower value/weight ratios for produce – high freight costs that are not fully offset by NNC subsidies, tend to inflate the price ratios of products with low value/weight ratios since they act like a tax on weight rather than the value of the product. While there was a modest increase in NNC subsidies in 2023, we see that freight cost increases were much higher, such that the net freight cost (the total freight cost minus the total subsidy) rose from $23.17 to $35.77.

We also observe that the difference between the Kinngait cost and the South cost is substantially lower than the net freight cost. This means that it is not profitable to buy in the South, at retail price, and ship to the Kinngait, at retail freight cost, even if one received the subsidy. It does not mean that retailers take a loss on these products, as it is possible that

they (a) pay a lower freight cost and
(b) pay a lower product cost.

Table 9. Kinngait example basket: local prices, Canadian prices, NNC subsidies, and freight

Product / component	Source	ICFI 2022 Q1/Q2	ICFI 2024 Q1/Q2	Arctic Fresh May 2026
Russet potatoes, 5 lb	Kinngait price	6.89	9.39	20.32
	Canada / base price	5.99	6.06	7.57
	NNC subsidy	13.05	13.39	13.39
	Freight	21.66	26.58	26.14
Baby carrots, 454 g	Kinngait price	3.49	4.29	7.10
	Canada / base price	1.22	1.18	4.56
	NNC subsidy	2.61	2.68	2.68
	Freight	4.33	5.32	5.22
Lactantia PurFiltre milk, 2% 2 L	Kinngait price	4.09	4.19	17.24
	Canada /base price	5.49	5.75	8.35
	NNC subsidy	12.90	13.70	13.70
	Freight	19.08	23.42	22.57
Bananas, 3 lb	Kinngait price	6.69	9.39	11.42
	Canada /base price	2.27	2.25	3.78
	NNC subsidy	7.82	8.02	8.03
	Freight	12.97	15.93	15.67

Note: Dollar values. The 2026 column reports Arctic Fresh delivered prices and reported base prices, freight charges, and NNC subsidies. Subsidy and freight totals reflect the product weights used in the example.

Table 9. Kinngait example basket: local prices, Canadian prices, NNC subsidies, and freight (continued)

Product / component	Source	ICFI 2022 Q1/Q2	ICFI 2024 Q1/Q2	Arctic Fresh May 2026
Lean ground beef, 400 g	Kinngait price	6.29	8.89	12.93
	Canada / base price	4.04	4.69	10.70
	NNC subsidy	2.30	2.36	2.33
	Freight	3.82	4.68	4.56
Basket totals	**Kinngait cost**	**27.45**	**36.15**	**69.01**
	Canada/base cost	19.02	19.92	34.95
	NNC subsidy	38.68	40.16	40.13
	Freight	61.86	75.93	74.16
	Net freight	23.17	35.77	34.03

Note: Dollar values. The 2026 column reports Arctic Fresh delivered prices and reported base prices, freight charges, and NNC subsidies. Subsidy and freight totals reflect the product weights used in the example.

Comparing the change in costs, the Kinngait basket cost rose by almost $9 while the Ottawa price rose less than $1, but the net freight for this basket rose over $12. Thus the "gross margin differential" decreased by about $4, although this need not imply that profits fell, as it may reflect differences in wholesale and freight costs we do not observe.

The third column, for Arctic Fresh in May 2026, shows much higher prices for the basket, although NNC and freight values are almost unchanged from 2024. The base costs are much higher, which may reflect inflation in the last two years or other factors, or the possibility that Arctic Fresh charges higher base prices for various reasons (e.g. transport from warehouse to the airport, higher wholesale prices or gross margins).

2.5.3 Example basket using Nunavut Price Survey data

We also consider a second basket for a longer-term 2017-2025 comparison using the Nunavut Price Survey, purchased in Sanirajak as shown in Table 10. This example basket includes 2L of 2% milk, a pound of margarine, a box of macaroni and cheese, a pound of wieners/hot dogs, and 1KG of bananas. This basket includes products with all possible NNC air freight subsidy levels – high for milk (after 2019), medium for bananas and wieners, low for margarine, and zero for macaroni and cheese. In 2017, purchasing this basket in Sanirajak cost 53% more than in Ottawa; milk was actually cheaper, while bananas (due to low value/weight) and margarine (due to low subsidy) were relatively expensive (3.44 and 1.98 times higher). By 2025, the cost of this basket was 79% higher in Sanirajak than Ottawa, due to 58% inflation in Sanirajak versus 35% inflation in Ottawa over 8 years. In 2025, macaroni and cheese was 2.4 times more expensive and bananas were 4.3 times more expensive, and even milk was 1.61 times more expensive.

The higher inflation in Sanirajak can be partly explained by the increase in freight, which outweighed the increase in NNC subsidy, such that freight costs net of the subsidy increased by almost $4. Note that for this example, all NNC subsidy rate increases are incorporated (2019, 2020, and 2023) but we only observe freight costs starting in 2021, so if anything we may underestimate the increase in freight costs.[16] For this basket, the Sanirajak cost increased by over $13, versus a $5 increase in the South and $4 increase in net freight. The difference -- $4 – reflects an increase in the "gross margin differential" which could be due to profits or other cost factors (including differences in wholesale costs and differences between observed and actual freight costs).

2.5.4 Estimates based on larger baskets

While the examples above illustrate factors that contribute to price levels and changes for specific products and communities, we can also consider more aggregated estimates based on the larger baskets and averaging across multiple communities. One obvious basket is the RNFB, for which we have prices at least once a quarter for 21 Nunavut communities through March 2025.

[16]As noted earlier, given that cargo rates were frozen in 2019 as part of the terms and conditions of the First Air - Canadian North merger approval, large increases in freight costs before 2021 are less likely but we cannot rule them out with the data available to us.

Table 10. Sanirajak example basket: local prices, Ottawa prices, NNC subsidies, and freight

Product / component	Source or component	2017	2025
2% milk, 2 L	Sanirajak price	3.62	8.94
	Ottawa price	4.41	5.53
	Freight	23.68	29.32
	NNC subsidy	11.20	16.30
Margarine, 454 g	Sanirajak price	5.89	8.23
	Ottawa price	2.97	5.99
	Freight	5.38	6.66
	NNC subsidy	1.73	2.43
Macaroni and cheese dinner, 200-225 g	Sanirajak price	2.97	4.44
	Ottawa price	1.88	1.84
	Freight	2.37	2.93
	NNC subsidy	0.00	0.00
Wieners, 450 g	Sanirajak price	5.79	7.39
	Ottawa price	4.39	5.21
	Freight	5.33	6.60
	NNC subsidy	2.54	3.13
Bananas, 1 kg	Sanirajak price	4.69	7.39
	Ottawa price	1.36	1.72
	Freight	11.84	14.66
	NNC subsidy	5.60	6.95

Note: Dollar values. Published freight data begin in 2021; the 2017 freight comparison therefore requires caution, as described in endnote 17.

Table 10. Sanirajak example basket: local prices, Ottawa prices, NNC subsidies, and freight (continued)

Product / component	Source or component	2017	2025
Basket totals	Sanirajak cost	22.96	36.39
	Ottawa cost	15.01	20.29
	Freight	48.59	60.16
	NNC subsidy	21.07	28.81
	Net freight	27.52	31.36

Note: Dollar values. Published freight data begin in 2021; the 2017 freight comparison therefore requires caution, as described in endnote 17.

To assess the contribution of freight, subsidies, and Southern prices, we combine the freight cost, subsidy, and "Southern RNFB" prices discussed earlier to estimate the relevant cost components for the entire RNFB basket. For freight cost, we consider a high freight cost scenario – assuming all 51.8KG of the RNFB is transported by air – and a low cost scenario, where non-perishables (13.6KG) are shipped by sea and charged based on weight (which is likely an underestimate since some of this freight may be charged based on a higher volume basis). For subsidies, we consider analogous scenarios, where either all eligible air freight subsidies are applied, or where non-perishables receive the surface freight subsidy where eligible.

For the "Southern RNFB," we use the cost of matched products (which add up to about 40KG out of 51.8KG of RNFB weight) and inflate the cost of the basket by a factor of 1.29, thereby assuming that the cost per kilogram of unmatched products is the same as for matched products. This is a source of bias but is at least somewhat limited by the relatively small share of the basket weight imputed using this assumption.

Table 11 presents the results, using September 2021 and March 2025 as the starting and end point. We see that the cost of the basket increased by almost $170 on average (averaged across 21 communities), implying 38.15% inflation. The cost of shipping the basket by air freight rose $104.82 or 21.6%, with only minimal increases in subsidies. The cost of shipping the basket by lowest cost freight (sea where possible) increased by $79.42 or 21.7%, with a similarly low (but slightly higher) increase in subsidies. Net freight cost (the freight cost minus the subsidy)

rose between $56.66 and $86.68 depending on the mode of transport, representing a 38% increase in net freight cost. The retail price of the basket in the South increased by $47.40, a 20.39% increase. Because inflation was higher in Nunavut than the South, the estimated price ratio rose from 2.02 to 2.55.

In terms of accounting for the increase in the Nunavut price, the increase in Southern RNFB price is equivalent to about 28% of the increase in the Nunavut RNFB price. The increase in net freight is between 33% (assuming lowest possible freight cost) and 52% (assuming all air freight cost). So combined, this accounts for 61%-80% of the increase in Nunavut RNFB price. This leaves a 20-39% increase in gross margin differential, which must account for any increases in local costs, unobserved freight costs, changes in Southern profit margins, and any changes in Nunavut profit margins.

Table 11. RNFB price decomposition for 21 Nunavut communities, Sept 2021-Mar 2025

Component	September 2021	March 2025	Change	Inflation	Share of RNFB price change
RNFB price	444.57	614.19	169.62	38.15%	100.00%
Air freight	484.97	589.79	104.82	21.61%	
Lower-cost freight scenario	366.22	445.64	79.42	21.69%	
Air-freight subsidy	249.84	265.98	16.14	6.46%	
Lower-cost subsidy scenario	217.72	240.48	22.76	10.45%	
Southern RNFB	232.50	279.90	47.40	20.39%	27.94%
Net freight - maximum	235.13	323.81	88.68	37.72%	52.28%
Net freight - minimum	148.50	205.16	56.66	38.15%	33.40%
Reported RNFB / Southern RNFB ratio	2.04	2.55			

Note: The lower-cost freight scenario assumes non-perishable products travel by sea where possible.

With the caveat that we do not observe actual freight costs or wholesale product costs, and our estimates of the latter based on incomplete Southern price data are likely to be particularly noisy, this analysis suggests both that there is scope for "higher retail profits" as an explanation for rising Nunavut prices and excess inflation, and that the scope for this is relatively limited in magnitude compared to the increases in freight (net of NNC subsidy) and Southern prices that can account for 61-80% of the increase in prices during the 2021-2025 period when the ICFI program was in effect. Note that this assessment is based on averaging across 21 Nunavut communities with consistent data during the period. When the analysis is done community by community, the change in net air freight and Southern RNFB closely tracks the timing and magnitude of changes in the RNFB in some communities (e.g. Arctic Bay, Pond Inlet, Gjoa Haven) but explains less of the increase in others.

Figure 22: RNFB Price and Air Freight Changes by Community, 2021–2025

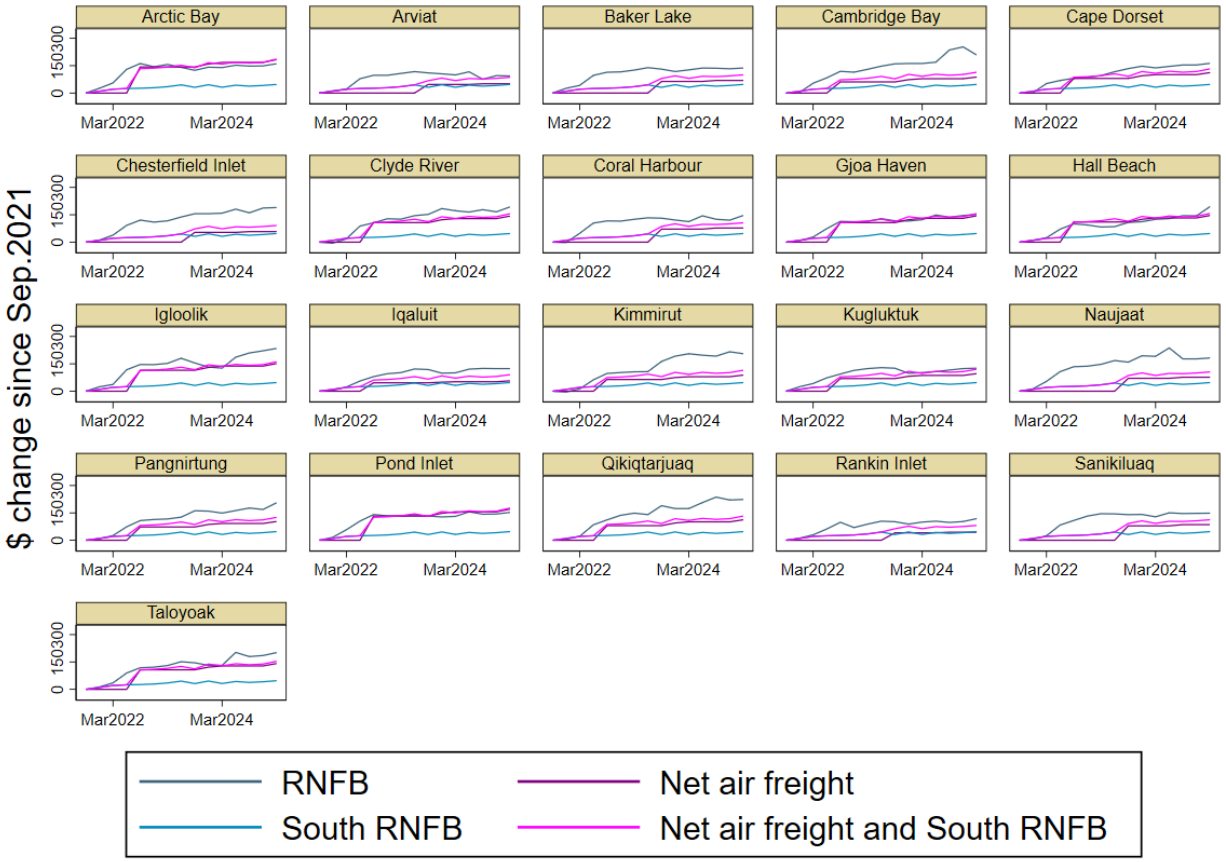


Figure 22 presents the change, relative to September 2021, of the quarterly RNFB, RNFB net air freight (after applying NNC subsidy), and Southern RNFB prices, for each period. Generally we find that these costs track better for Kitikmeot and Qikiqtaaluk communities; the public Calm Air freight prices from Winnipeg change more slowly and account for a smaller share of the increase in RNFB prices. Table 12 provides a summary picture for Qikiqtaaluk (10 communities with North West Company stores) broken down into two sub-periods, from March 2021-2023 and March 2023-2025, that roughly coincide with the period before and after the first adoption of the ICFI Hamlet Food Voucher program. The top panel reproduces the RNFB cost, estimated Southern RNFB cost (e.g. contribution of Southern food prices and markups), and RNFB freight and subsidy rates. The bottom panel shows inflation for the RNFB and the contributing factors were much higher in the earlier 2021-2023 period than the later 2023-2025 period, but that a slightly higher share of the increase in RNFB cost can be "explained" in the later period. Over either period, or the entire 2021-2025 period, the share of RNFB cost increase that can be "explained" by the rise in air freight costs (net of NNC subsidy) and Southern RNFB costs is in the 77%-85% range.

Together, increases in Southern RNFB prices and net air freight account for 77%-85% of the increase in RNFB prices, leaving a residual of 15%-23%. This residual could reflect increases in local retailer margins or profits, but it could also reflect increases in local operating costs that are not captured in our analysis, including wages, energy, maintenance, and additional freight or delivery costs to and from airports. For example, Nunavut's minimum wage rose from $16 to $19 in January 2024. We cannot distinguish between these explanations with the data available. The increase in Southern RNFB prices may itself reflect higher costs and/or margins among Southern manufacturers and retailers, but these are already incorporated in the Southern-price component of the decomposition.

Table 12. RNFB cost decomposition for 10 Qikiqtaaluk communities, 2021-2025

Measure			
Cost levels ($)	**2021**	**2023**	**2025**
RNFB	437	572	634
Southern RNFB	231	267	280
RNFB freight – high	566	656	696
RNFB freight – low	427	495	525
RNFB NNC subsidy – high	318	340	340
RNFB NNC subsidy – low	271	297	297
Inflation	**2021-2023**	**2023-2025**	**2021-2025**
RNFB	31%	11%	45%
Southern RNFB	16%	5%	21%
RNFB freight – high	16%	6%	23%
RNFB freight – low	16%	6%	23%
RNFB NNC subsidy – high	7%	0%	7%
RNFB NNC subsidy – low	10%	0%	10%
Change in dollars			
RNFB	135	62	197
Southern RNFB	36	13	49
Net air freight	68	40	108
Share of RNFB change explained			
Southern RNFB	27%	21%	25%
Net air freight	50%	65%	55%
Southern RNFB + net air freight	77%	85%	80%

Note: Cost levels correspond to the years shown above. The two subperiods 2021-2023 and 2023-2025 roughly align with the period before and during the HFV phase-in.

3. Recommendations

Our analysis here suggests several avenues for improving data collection and understanding of Nunavut food prices going forward. These are relevant both for government bodies tasked with data collection and reporting going forward (e.g. Nunavut Bureau of Statistics, Nutrition North Canada, Statistics Canada) and researchers.

3.1 Report detailed, product-level prices instead of basket costs

Both the ICFI receipt data and the Nunavut Price Survey contain, product-level prices, with the former including specific brands and stores, and the latter including multiple pack sizes and in some cases varieties (for meat, produce, milk, cereal). These data reveal both the extent of missing data/unavailable products, and the sometimes substantial price differences – measured in $/unit weight terms – that exist for a given product type like milk, beef, or apple juice.

Product level data allows researchers to (a) weight products according to their importance to households, and (b) achieve a better match to other data sets (like Southern retail data). Observing multiple brand names and product sizes allow for analysis of economically interesting phenomena like product substitutions, quality, and bulk discounting.

Conversely, reporting basket-level prices like the RNFB necessarily requires imputations when products are missing and obscures interesting details. It requires assigning weights that are ultimately arbitrary and do not reflect economically meaningful consumption patterns. And it makes apples-to-apples comparisons with other data sets more challenging.

3.2 Consider a diverse set of products, including popular non-subsidized foods

Some of the basket price estimates that are widely reported and cited – the RNFB, and the 24-product "Nunavut Food Basket – are mostly or entirely restricted to NNC subsidized

products. This understates the true cost-of-living and may also obscure inflation when freight costs rise, especially during periods when NNC subsidy rates increase. In general, little is known about inflation of non-subsidized products. The ICFI data include many unsubsidized products, and the Nunavut Price Survey contains some, which is a good start, but even in these more comprehensive data sets many important non-subsidized products are excluded. Any comparison to CPI inflation that excludes this large category of goods – which is included in CPI – is likely to be biased, with an unknown direction of bias.

3.3 Collect data on actual expenditures/quantities and use these as weights

Price indexes meant to capture living cost differences across locations (as in the IPAI Living Cost Differential index) or time (as in the Consumer Price Index and its components) weight price differences/changes by quantities or expenditures. These quantities/expenditures are captured using representative consumer surveys, although retailer-level scanner data could serve a similar purpose (as in the Nunivaat program in Nunavik).[17]

Given the wide dispersion of price ratios across products – both within subsidized products, and across different subsidy levels – weighting these products is essential when attempting to capture a meaningful "average" for households. Arbitrary and non-representative weights, like those used by the RNFB and the MBM, are typically less informative than those based on actual consumption patterns. The lack of data on representative consumption patterns in Nunavut is a major gap in the current state of knowledge, and collecting/reporting such data would likely be the single largest contribution to a better understanding of cost-of-living in Nunavut. The Survey of Household Spending (collected for Iqaluit) and NNC's data on subsidized shipments are promising for this purpose but both inadequate in important respects; the former because Iqaluit is highly unusual among Nunavut communities and the Survey of Household Spending only tracks expenditures, not quantities, and the latter because data on unsubsidized shipments by category is also necessary for this purpose.

A potential advantage of collecting household-level consumption data is that inflation indexes can be constructed for different types of households. Given the large

[17]See https://www.nunivaat.org/research-program/

socioeconomic and demographic differences between Inuit and non-Inuit households, household with higher education and government jobs versus those without, and households with young children and those without, we might expect large differences in consumption patterns that imply different group-level inflation rates and cost-of-living differentials. These patterns cannot be assessed using store or community level data. An example of the insights from this type of analysis can be found in Daley, Galloway, Li and Watson (2026) who show that NNC subsidies provide greater benefit to high income households.

3.4 Collect data on freight mode and actual retailer freight costs if possible

While estimates of freight costs for perishables are relatively straightforward, estimates of freight costs for non-perishables need to make assumptions about transportation mode that are not based on actual data. Collecting data on freight mode should be straightforward since there is a one-to-one mapping to subsidy levels and should be standard when prices are collected/reported. This allows for correct application of NNC subsidies and linkage with the appropriate freight cost.

Estimates of actual retailer freight costs (and quantities shipped using different modes) would be equally useful, although retailers may be reluctant to share these data since paying freight costs below published/public rates is one of their main sources of competitive advantage (and hence margins and profits).

3.5 Ensure that comparisons with the South reflect the same products

Related to points 3.1 and 3.3, comparisons of different baskets of goods with different weights are not likely to be informative about relative inflation. We saw this in section 1.3, where RNFB Nunavut inflation was compared to RNFB Canada inflation and CPI Food-at-home Canada inflation. The different product baskets, with different weights, lead to substantially different conclusions about inflation in Nunavut versus the rest of Canada. Collecting and reporting data on comparable products in the South is relatively simple, as this report demonstrates.

3.6 Retailer cooperation

Many of the questions about Nunavut food prices – how much they have increased for subsidized and unsubsidized products, how much of different types of products are consumed, what is the contribution of freight costs to

inflation – could be easily answered by retailers using their data. While retailers may be understandably reluctant to share their data with government, NGOs, the press, and academics, to the extent that high inflation and high price levels *are not a result of higher profit margins* it will also benefit them to provide data supporting this position. And if data on freight costs and margins are deemed too sensitive, providing prices, quantities/expenditures, or inflation measures combining these – at whatever levels of aggregation are deemed disclosable – would still be informative. The Nunivaat program in Nunavik, which involves sharing scanner data between the FCNQ and Laval University, may provide a useful model for similar collaborations in Nunavut.

3.7 Consider web-scraped price data

Several online retailers serving Nunavut report delivered prices – alongside freight costs, subsidies, and base prices – for communities in Nunavut. As these data are updated in real time, and cover a wide range of products, they are a potentially useful supplement (though not a substitute) for prices reported/collected for local stores.

Online retailers in the South also report prices, which have been collected by companies like BetterCart Analytics (our partner on this analysis) and other parties, such as the FLIP collected by L'Abbe Labs at the University of Toronto.[18] These data are useful and potentially a lower cost method for collecting matched prices in Southern markets than store-level surveys, and allow us to assess differences in the cost ratio of specific products or baskets.

[18] See https://labbelab.utoronto.ca/projects/food-label-information-price-flip/

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